

The Heart of Dhamma Practice 2.5

A Map Based on the Early Suttas, a Practical Workbook, and a Glossary of Pali Terms

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How to Read This Document

This is a map, a set of checks, and a collection of practical exercises for investigating *dukkha*, *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, *bhava*, *anattā*, and *paṭiccasamuppāda* in one's own experience.

This document does not claim to be 100% accurate or complete. It may contain errors and imprecise formulations.

Pali terms are retained where a standard English rendering can easily distort their meaning. For example, *dukkha* means more than “suffering,” *taṇhā* is not simply any desire, *upādāna* is more than strong attachment, *bhava* means more than “existence,” and *anattā* is not a declaration that “I do not exist.”

The best way to use this text is to take one passage at a time and test it in daily life. If the practice becomes a source of tension, contempt, pride, or fear, something has been misunderstood. If it leads to greater clarity, gentleness, sobriety, letting go, and reduced reactivity, the direction is sound.

0. Preliminary Foundation: Health, Sobriety, and Values

The practice of Dhamma does not take place in a vacuum. The body, the psyche, trauma, habits, social environment, and values all condition whether practice is sound, safe, and free from avoidance. Before engaging in subtler work with *dukkha*, *taṇhā*, and *anattā*, it is therefore useful to examine this foundation honestly.

Area	What matters here	Practical criterion
Psychiatry and neurology	Severe disorders, neurological conditions, and states requiring medical care.	When there is a risk of self-harm, psychosis, severe insomnia, panic, or sudden deterioration, professional help is needed, rather than an attempt to endure heroically through practice.
Psychological health	Trauma, attachment patterns, emotions, and the capacity for kindness and connection.	Practice makes behavior gentler, more honest, and more responsible, not colder, prouder, or more detached.
Cognitive clarity	The ability to notice patterns and errors in thinking, projections, and self-deception.	Less dogmatism and fewer abrupt conclusions; more consistency and clarity.

Area	What matters here	Practical criterion
Values	A shift away from personal gain toward what is beneficial, toward simplicity, and toward the Dhamma as the highest value.	Less preoccupation with status and pleasure, and greater interest in practice.
Self-observation	The skill of seeing body, feelings, mind, and <i>dhammā</i> as processes.	Instead of “this is what I am,” one begins to note: “a condition, feeling, craving, or impulse has arisen.”

Not every form of meditation is automatically a practice of liberation. Meditation may be used for stability, clarity, and reducing anxiety. In this document, the central criterion is: does the practice weaken *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and *avijjā*, and lead toward the cessation of *dukkha*?

Meditation is better understood not as a mechanical algorithm, but as a living and, in some respects, creative process. The Buddha gave a method, a direction, and verifiable conditions: *sīla*, *sati*, *samādhi*, *paññā*, the abandoning of *taṇhā*, and the cultivation of *magga*. But there is no single fixed sequence guaranteed to lead to *Nibbāna*. The path cultivates conditions for the ending of craving and clinging. *Nibbāna* is not produced by a technique and is not a conditioned result.

Caution: meditation should not replace treatment where medical care is needed. If practice intensifies alienation, insomnia, fear, obsession, or contempt for others, that is a warning sign.

1. Testing the Dhamma: Eight Criteria from AN 8.53

A good safeguard against spiritual self-deception is to look beyond appealing words to their results. [AN 8.53](#) provides a filter: what leads to dispassion, freedom, simplicity, and less strain may be recognized as being in accordance with the Dhamma and Vinaya (*Dhamma-Vinaya*).

Criterion	Meaning	Question for checking
<i>virāga</i> , not <i>sarāga</i>	Toward dispassion, not passion.	After practice, is there less attraction, passion, and dependence?
<i>visaṃyoga</i> , not <i>saṃyoga</i>	Toward release from bonds, not bondage.	Is there less of “I must obtain/prove/hold on to this”?
<i>apacaya</i> , not <i>ācaya</i>	Toward reduction, not accumulation.	Is there less mental proliferation, status-building, and accumulation of concepts?
<i>appicchatā</i> , not <i>mahicchatā</i>	Toward few wishes, not many.	Is there less need for stimulation, recognition, validation, or special status?

Criterion	Meaning	Question for checking
<i>santuṭṭhi</i> , not <i>asantuṭṭhi</i>	Toward contentment, not discontentment.	Does a sense of sufficiency arise, so that one no longer feels compelled to keep improving conditions or seeking new experiences?
<i>paviveka</i> , not <i>saṅgaṇikā</i>	Toward seclusion, not constant company.	Does the mind seek less noise, argument, confirmation, and novelty?
<i>vīriyārambha</i> , not <i>kosajja</i>	Toward arousing energy, not laziness.	Is there energetic and steady effort without violence toward oneself?
<i>subharatā</i> , not <i>dubbharatā</i>	Toward being easy to support, not demanding or fastidious.	Is the person becoming less demanding in daily life and relationships?

If a teaching or practice increases dependence, fear, craving for status, harshness, a sense of specialness, or contempt for others, it should be thoroughly re-examined.

The complexity of a system does not prove that it leads closer to liberation. The criterion remains practical: are *lobha*, *dosa*, *moha*, *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and *māna* becoming weaker?

2. Doctrinal Core

This map does not exhaust the Dhamma, but it helps make visible the framework of practice found in the early suttas.

The Four Noble Truths (*ariyasacca*)

1. *dukkha* - the unsatisfactory and unreliable nature of conditioned experience.
2. *samudaya* - the arising of *dukkha* through *taṇhā*.
3. *nirodha* - the cessation of *dukkha* through the cessation of *taṇhā*.
4. *magga* - the path to cessation, namely the Noble Eightfold Path.

The Noble Eightfold Path (*ariya aṭṭhaṅgika magga*)

Group	Factors
<i>paññā</i> - wisdom	<i>sammā-diṭṭhi</i> - right view; <i>sammā-saṅkappa</i> - right intention.
<i>sīla</i> - ethical conduct	<i>sammā-vācā</i> - right speech; <i>sammā-kammanta</i> - right action; <i>sammā-ājīva</i> - right livelihood.
<i>samādhi</i> - meditative collectedness	<i>sammā-vāyāma</i> - right effort; <i>sammā-sati</i> - right mindfulness/recollection; <i>sammā-samādhi</i> - right collectedness, defined in the standard formula as the four <i>jhānas</i> .

The Five Hindrances (*nīvaraṇa*)

- *kāmacchanda* - sensual desire.

- *vyāpāda* - ill will, irritation.
- *thīna-middha* - dullness and drowsiness.
- *uddhacca-kukkucca* - restlessness and remorse.
- *vicikicchā* - doubt that obstructs practice.

The Seven Factors of Awakening (*bojjhaṅgā*)

- *sati* - mindfulness/recollection.
- *dhammavicaya* - investigation of phenomena.
- *virīya* - energy, diligence.
- *pīti* - joy, rapture.
- *passaddhi* - tranquility.
- *samādhi* - collectedness.
- *upekkhā* - equanimity.

Additional Supports

- *mettā* - goodwill, an antidote to *dosa*.
- *asubha* - contemplation of unattractiveness, an antidote to sensual enchantment.
- *yoniso manasikāra* - wise direction of attention.
- *indriya-saṃvara* - restraint of the sense faculties.

The Three Unwholesome Roots

[Iti 50](#) names three roots of the unwholesome:

- *lobha* - greed, passionate attraction;
- *dosa* - aversion, hostility;
- *moha* - delusion, mental obscuration.

Lobha, *dosa*, and *moha* describe the roots of the unwholesome, whereas *avijjā*, *taṇhā*, and *upādāna* describe different conditions in the unfolding of *dukkha*. One triad should therefore not be used as a direct substitute for the other.

3. The Field of Experience: *sabba* and the Six Sense Fields

In [SN 35.23](#), the Buddha limits “the all” to what is actually given in experience: the eye and forms, the ear and sounds, the nose and odors, the tongue and tastes, the body and tangibles, and the mind and mental phenomena.

For practice, this means beginning with what is experienced right now: what is seen, heard, or felt in the body, as well as feelings, thoughts, images, intentions, and reactions. There is no need first to settle whether “the world exists in itself,” and so forth. The practical question is simpler and more concrete: how does feeling arise from contact, how does craving arise from feeling, how does clinging arise from craving, and how can this be brought to an end?

The Six Sense Fields (*āyatana*)

Sense field	Object	Consciousness	Contact
Eye	form	visual consciousness	visual <i>phassa</i>
Ear	sound	auditory consciousness	auditory <i>phassa</i>
Nose	odor	olfactory consciousness	olfactory <i>phassa</i>

Sense field	Object	Consciousness	Contact
Tongue	taste	gustatory consciousness	gustatory <i>phassa</i>
Body	tangible object	bodily consciousness	bodily <i>phassa</i>
Mind	ideas, images, memories	mental consciousness	mental <i>phassa</i>

An important practical conclusion follows: a thought, concept, image, memory, or fantasy is just as much an object of practice as a sound or a bodily sensation. The mind can cling to these as well.

Here “the eye” means more than the anatomical organ or a fixed bodily entity. It is a changing, conditioned sense faculty participating in the process of seeing. In dependence on the eye and visible form, visual consciousness arises; the conjunction of these three is called contact, and contact conditions feeling. The other sense fields work in the same way.

In [MN 38](#), consciousness is compared to a fire that is named after its fuel: a wood fire, grass fire, or straw fire. Likewise, consciousness is designated according to the conditions on which it arises: visual consciousness arises in dependence on the eye and forms, auditory consciousness on the ear and sounds, and mental consciousness on the mind and mental objects. Consciousness here is not an independent bearer of experience; each type arises when the relevant conditions are present.

Mind as an Internal Sense Field

Within this map of experience, mind is neither a hidden master nor an eternal observer. It is one of the six internal sense fields. The eye encounters visible forms; the ear, sounds; the nose, odors; the tongue, tastes; the body, tactile objects; and the mind, mental phenomena.

Thoughts, images, memories, and concepts connected with what was seen, heard, or felt may become objects of the mental sense field. A sensory episode can therefore continue as an inner story: “this is a danger,” “this is about me,” “I must respond.” Here the mind is not a hidden master gathering the whole of experience, but another conditioned process.

It is therefore useful to see the mind as a conditioned process. It arises depending on conditions, functions depending on conditions, and does not own experience.

How “a Being” and “the World” Are Constructed

What we call “the world” is experienced through the six sense fields. What we call “a being” is constructed in relation to the five aggregates: body or form, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness. The error begins not with the process of seeing or hearing itself, but with appropriation.

The visible becomes “what I see.” A feeling becomes “my feeling.” A thought becomes “my opinion.” A memory becomes “my story.” Under ignorance, “I,” “mine,” and “for me” are added to what is seen, heard, felt, and thought. Conditioned experience thus becomes the basis of a personal story and further clinging.

Practice does not require denying what is seen, heard, or felt. It teaches one to see how “I” and “mine” are added to experience.

In this account, the mind is neither the creator of the world nor the first cause of *saṃsāra*. In [SN 35.82](#), the “world” is disclosed through the sense fields, the corresponding kinds of consciousness, contact, and feeling, which arise and cease according to conditions.

It is therefore more accurate to say not that the mind creates *saṃsāra*, but that the *saṃsāric* process is nourished when ignorance, craving, clinging, and formative reactions are present. Mind is part of this conditionality, not its master or source.

4. The Horizon of Practice: *Nibbāna* as *asaṅkhata*

Within the framework of the early suttas, *Nibbāna* should not be reduced to a trance, non-being, a blank mental screen, a pleasant state, dissociation, or a meditative attainment that can be maintained. It is *asaṅkhata*: the unmade, the unconditioned, not arisen as a composite process. The Pali texts [Iti 43](#) and [Ud 8.3](#) speak of the unborn, the unoriginated, and the unmade, by virtue of which release from the born and made is possible.

It is important to distinguish the following:

- Calming the mind is a valuable condition, but not liberation itself.
- The cessation of a particular chain is a useful small-scale experience of *nirodha*, but is not necessarily *Nibbāna*.
- Deep states of *samādhi* can support wisdom, but if one clings to them, they become a subtle form of *bhava*.
- *Nibbāna* is not appropriated as “my attainment.” If a new identity is built around liberation, there is already good reason for doubt.

Nibbāna Is Not a “True Self”

A misunderstanding may arise: the body is not “self,” feelings are not “self,” perception, formations, and consciousness are not “self,” so there must be a real “self” somewhere behind them. *Nibbāna* is then understood as a true essence, pure consciousness, and so forth. This is often conditioned by craving for existence.

But the Buddha examined the five *khandhā* not so that they could be rejected and another “self” found, but in order to recognize the mechanism of clinging itself. The five aggregates encompass the entire field of conditioned experience that the mind may take as “I” and “mine”: body or form, feeling, perception, formative activities, and consciousness.

Nibbāna is therefore neither an eternal “self” nor the annihilation of a “self.” There is nothing to annihilate: an independent self is found neither in any aggregate nor outside them. What ceases is not a self, but the craving, clinging, becoming, and *dukkha* that sustained the idea of a self.

Nibbāna should not be understood as a conditioned state of consciousness produced by a technique, maintained by effort, and then brought to an end. The early texts disclose it primarily through the cessation of craving, dispassion, cessation, and the unconditioned, without introducing a new entity, a “true observer,” or a subtler mode of existence.

Beyond Existence and Non-existence

The Buddha did not reduce liberation to the statement “I exist” or to the statement “I do not exist.” Both formulas still revolve around “I.” In the first, the mind seeks a footing in existence; in the second, a footing in non-existence.

Practice goes deeper. It shows how the very framework “I am” arises from ignorance, craving, clinging, and becoming. When ignorance is recognized as ignorance, this framework loses its nourishment. The mind then no longer needs to seek salvation in either existence or non-existence.

Stages of Awakening and the Ten *saṃyojana*

In the suttas, stages of awakening are described primarily through the weakening or cutting of fetters (*saṃyojana*), not through the experience of unusual states. This is a map of release from clinging, not a set of titles and not a reason to build an identity around “my attainment.”

Stage	What changes	Practical meaning
<i>sotāpanna</i> - stream-enterer	The first three fetters are cut: <i>sakkāya-diṭṭhi</i> , <i>vicikicchā</i> , and <i>silabbata-parāmāsa</i> .	The view that the self is identical with one or more of the five aggregates, possesses them, contains them, or is contained in them; doubt concerning the Dhamma; attachment to rules and rituals.
<i>sakadāgāmin</i> - once-returner	The first three fetters are cut; sensual desire and ill will are noticeably weakened.	Reactions are still possible, but their strength, frequency, and power over the mind have already been substantially reduced.
<i>anāgāmin</i> - non-returner	The five lower fetters are cut, including <i>kāmacchanda</i> and <i>vyāpāda</i> .	Sensual craving and ill will no longer govern the mind.
<i>arahant</i> - fully liberated	All ten fetters are cut, including <i>rūparāga</i> , <i>arūparāga</i> , <i>māna</i> , <i>uddhacca</i> , and <i>avijjā</i> .	Craving, clinging to <i>rūpa</i> and <i>arūpa</i> , conceit, restlessness, and ignorance have ceased; experience is no longer appropriated as “I” and “mine.”

In [MN 64](#), the absence of an overt manifestation of a fetter does not mean that it has been finally removed. The corresponding underlying tendency (*anusaya*) may remain and manifest when suitable conditions arise. This is illustrated by the example of an infant: a fully formed identity view, doubt, sensual desire, or hostility does not yet arise in the infant, but the corresponding tendencies have not been removed.

The term *saṃyojana* describes a defilement as a condition that sustains clinging and further becoming. The term *anusaya* denotes an unremoved predisposition that may temporarily remain unmanifest. The terms are closely related but not fully interchangeable. [AN 10.13](#) lists ten fetters, whereas [AN 7.11](#) lists seven underlying tendencies. The temporary absence of desire, hostility, or doubt therefore does not yet mean freedom from them.

A *sotāpanna* is described as one in whom the first three fetters have been cut. In practical terms, this may be understood as a profound and irreversible undermining of the footing on which “I” is built in experience. *Sakkāya-diṭṭhi* loses its power: the mind can no longer take the *khandhā* as “I,” “mine,” or “this is what I am” in the same naive way.

Avijjā, *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and *māna* cease completely only in an arahant.

What Has Ceased for an Arahant

The cessation of *dukkha* in an arahant does not mean the disappearance of the body, sense faculties, contact, and feeling. As long as an arahant is alive, the five *khandhā* continue to function: seeing, hearing, bodily sensations, and pleasant, unpleasant, and neutral *vedanā* can arise. There may be bodily pain, fatigue, hunger, illness, and aging.

What ceases is not the functioning of the aggregates, but their appropriation as “I” and “mine.” An arahant may therefore experience the first arrow, such as bodily pain or unpleasant contact, but the second arrow does not arise: mental suffering constructed from craving, resistance, fear, resentment, and conceit.

An arahant need not appear outwardly unusual, omniscient, continuously blissful, insensible, or endowed with magical powers. Liberation is not determined by status, way of life, or miracles. What matters is the cessation of *avijjā*, *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, *māna*, and *bhava*.

No.	<i>Samyojana</i>	Meaning
1	<i>sakkāya-diṭṭhi</i>	identity view based on the five aggregates
2	<i>vicikicchā</i>	doubt that undermines confidence in the Dhamma and practice.
3	<i>sīlabbata-parāmāsa</i>	clinging to rules, vows, observances, and to the Dhamma as an end in itself.
4	<i>kāmacchanda</i>	sensual desire, attraction to sensual pleasures.
5	<i>vyāpāda</i>	ill will, hostility, rejection.
6	<i>rūparāga</i>	desire for subtle-material existence, clinging to <i>rūpa</i> levels.
7	<i>arūparāga</i>	desire for formless existence, clinging to <i>arūpa</i> levels.
8	<i>māna</i>	conceit, comparison, the subtle “I am.”
9	<i>uddhacca</i>	restlessness, subtle instability of mind.
10	<i>avijjā</i>	ignorance of the Four Noble Truths and the conditioned arising of <i>dukkha</i> .

It is useful to distinguish *sakkāya-diṭṭhi* from *māna*. *Sakkāya-diṭṭhi* is the view that body, feeling, perception, formations, or consciousness are “self,” belong to a self, are within a self, or contain a self. *Māna* is subtler: it is the habit of centering experience around “I am,” “I experience,” “I understood,” “I am superior,” “I am inferior,” or “I am equal.” One might put it this way: after a flower is removed, its fragrance remains for a time. In the same way, after a coarse view of self has weakened, a subtle trace of “I am” may remain.

In [MN 22](#), the Buddha compares the Dhamma to a raft: the raft is needed for crossing over, not to be carried on one’s head after the crossing. In the same discourse, grasping the Dhamma wrongly is compared to seizing a snake by the wrong end. If the teaching is taken up for argument, status, self-assertion, or views, it may cause harm instead of liberation.

Even *sati*, *samādhi*, the *jhānas*, wisdom, and “my path” can become new objects of *upādāna* if the mind builds an identity around them.

Letting go of clinging to the Dhamma does not mean ceasing to distinguish the wholesome from the unwholesome. According to [AN 9.7](#), intentional killing, theft, sexual intercourse, and lying are impossible for an arahant monk.

In practice, this scheme should be used not to claim stages for oneself or assign them to others, but to check the direction: are identity views, doubt, clinging, sensual craving, ill will, conceit, and ignorance becoming weaker? The criteria are qualitative. Another person's stage cannot be determined infallibly from outward signs, isolated experiences, or declarations. Such an assessment requires the corresponding direct knowledge possessed by the Buddha and some arahants. Statements such as "I am definitely a *sotāpanna*" are not a reliable criterion of attainment and may feed *māna* and *upādāna*, revealing clinging to views.

5. The Four Noble Truths: Tasks, Not Merely Propositions

The Four Noble Truths matter not only as facts, but as practical tasks. In the Pali version of [SN 56.11](#), the knowledge-and-vision of each truth unfolds in three rounds: knowledge of the truth, knowledge of the task appropriate to it, and knowledge that the task has been completed. Together these make twelve aspects.

Truth	What is to be recognized	Task
<i>dukkha ariyasacca</i>	Conditioned experience is unreliable and does not provide final satisfaction.	<i>pariññeyya</i> - to be fully understood.
<i>samudaya ariyasacca</i>	<i>Dukkha</i> arises from <i>taṇhā</i> : craving for sensuality, becoming, and non-becoming.	<i>pahātabba</i> - to be abandoned.
<i>nirodha ariyasacca</i>	With the cessation of <i>taṇhā</i> , <i>dukkha</i> ceases.	<i>sacchikātabba</i> - to be realized.
<i>magga ariyasacca</i>	There is a path of practice leading to cessation.	<i>bhāvetabba</i> - to be developed and brought to realization.

Three Kinds of *dukkha*

It is useful to distinguish three aspects of *dukkha*.

- ***Dukkha-dukkhatā*** - evident painfulness: bodily pain, mental pain, grief, sorrow, dejection, and despair.
- ***Vipariṇāma-dukkhatā*** - the unsatisfactoriness of change. Even a pleasant feeling is not a reliable support: it changes, disappears, and, when clung to, becomes a cause of suffering.
- ***Saṅkhāra-dukkhatā*** - the unreliability of all that is conditioned. Everything composite depends on conditions, is not under full control, and is subject to change and dissolution; it therefore cannot be a final refuge.

Dukkha is not limited to pain. Pain is its coarsest layer. Deeper lie the unsatisfactoriness of change and the very unreliability of conditioned processes.

A practical formula:

- *dukkha* is to be seen so clearly that one stops seeking a final refuge in anything conditioned;
- *taṇhā* is to be recognized in the moment, not merely condemned after the fact;
- *nirodha* is to be tested as the actual cessation of craving and clinging;
- *magga* is to be developed through body, speech, livelihood, attention, and collectedness.

6. *Magga*: the Path as an Integrated Training

The path is not reducible to meditation, philosophy, reading suttas, or special experiences. It is integrated: view shapes intention; intention purifies speech and action; ethics supports freedom from remorse; freedom from remorse facilitates joy, tranquility, and collectedness; and a collected mind becomes fit for knowledge-and-vision. This is well reflected in [AN 11.2](#): wholesome qualities do not operate as isolated components, but support one another as a chain of conditions.

[Dhp 19–20](#) emphasizes that it is better to know a little and live in accordance with the Dhamma than to know many texts without putting them into practice.

It is useful to review *sīla* regularly: speech, actions, livelihood, and one’s observance of the precepts. Such review is needed not to generate guilt, but to recognize mistakes clearly, adjust conditions, and refine the practice.

The word *sammā* in the Eightfold Path is usually translated as “right.” Here it is not a badge of group membership or a moral label. “Right” means what leads to the cessation of *dukkha*, weakens *lobha*, *dosa*, and *moha*, does not sustain clinging to “I,” and accords with the Four Noble Truths.

The path is called eightfold for a reason: all eight factors support one another. Omitting one factor, or substituting something else for it, compromises the integrity and effectiveness of the training.

The column “Common Distortions” lists only a few typical errors, not every possible deviation. Standard definitions of the eight path factors are given in [SN 45.8](#).

Further examples of wrong directions can be found in the suttas: [DN 1](#) examines numerous speculative views; [MN 19](#) distinguishes intentions of sensuality, ill will, and harmfulness from their wholesome opposites; [MN 41](#) lists unwholesome forms of conduct by body, speech, and mind; [MN 117](#) contrasts wrong and right view, intention, speech, action, and livelihood; and [AN 5.177](#) names five kinds of trade a lay follower should avoid.

[DN 1](#) also shows the conditioned nature of views. Memory, reasoning, and meditative experiences themselves arise from conditions. If contact, feeling, craving, and clinging are not recognized, such experience easily becomes a basis for views about the self and the world.

The Eight Factors of the Path

Factor	What <i>sammā</i> means	Common distortions
<i>sammā-diṭṭhi</i> - right view	Seeing <i>dukkha</i> , its arising, its cessation, and the path; understanding <i>kamma</i> , <i>paṭiccasamuppāda</i> , impermanence, and the impersonal nature of the <i>khandhā</i> .	A view of an eternal self, an observing soul, or pure consciousness as an essence; the nihilistic claim “there is no one, so nothing matters”; clinging to an opinion as proof that “I am right.”
<i>sammā-saṅkappa</i> - right intention	The intention of renunciation, non-ill-will, and harmlessness; directing the mind toward relinquishment rather than acquisition.	Plans for sensual gratification, revenge, self-assertion, or the suppression of oneself or others; spiritual ambition.

Factor	What <i>sammā</i> means	Common distortions
<i>sammā-vācā</i> - right speech	Abstaining from false, divisive, harsh, and idle speech; speech that is timely, truthful, beneficial, and does not nourish <i>dosa</i> .	Sarcasm, gossip, pressure, argument for the sake of self-assertion, “truth” used as a weapon, and spiritual labels used to demean.
<i>sammā-kammanta</i> - right action	Bodily actions that do not harm: abstaining from killing, stealing, and sexual misconduct; within a broader ethical foundation, also abstaining from intoxicants; care for living beings.	Harm justified by utility, goals, practice, or emotion; indulgence of impulses; ascetic violence toward the body.
<i>sammā-ājīva</i> - right livelihood	A way of earning a living that is not built on harm, deceit, exploitation, or the intensification of defilements.	Income obtained through violence or deception, by exploiting people’s dependence, or by manipulating fear, craving, or spiritual authority.
<i>sammā-vāyāma</i> - right effort	The four efforts: preventing unwholesome states from arising, abandoning arisen unwholesome states, developing wholesome states, and maintaining arisen wholesome states.	Laziness and distraction, but also violence toward oneself, suppressing desires without understanding, and harsh, joyless overexertion.
<i>sammā-sati</i> - right mindfulness/recollection	Mindfulness of body, feeling, mind, and <i>dhammā</i> as processes that arise and cease; <i>satipaṭṭhāna</i> .	A dissociated observer, a mechanical “came and went,” or retreat into vague awareness without distinguishing <i>taṇhā</i> and <i>upādāna</i> .
<i>sammā-samādhi</i> - right collectedness	Collectedness free from the hindrances and supportive of wisdom; in the standard formula, the four <i>jhānas</i> .	Chasing states, dependence on calm, pride in attainments, and mistaking trance or blankness for liberation.

The Noble Path may unfold differently for different practitioners. In [AN 4.162](#), both painful and pleasant practice are distinguished, and either may lead to slow or swift realization.

Magga means not mere movement, but directed practice leading to liberation. The Buddha describes it through eight interconnected factors that are developed gradually.

It is not enough merely to feel that one is moving forward: in a forest, one may be certain one is walking toward the way out while still going in circles. Moreover, as long as the mind remains defiled, a person is not always able to assess their own position correctly. The direction of practice therefore cannot be checked by a single inner impression. One must compare one’s practice with the Buddha’s instructions, observe its effects in behavior and the state of mind, and, when necessary, seek guidance from experienced and trustworthy practitioners. What matters is lasting change over time: are craving, hostility, and ignorance

weakening, and are the factors of the path developing?

Neither the difficulty nor the ease of practice, by itself, shows whether the direction has been chosen correctly or how quickly liberation will be attained.

Right Intention Before an Action

Right intention (*sammā-saṅkappa*) directs the mind toward renunciation, goodwill, and harmlessness. It does not guarantee that craving, hostility, or fear will disappear immediately. The task is to establish a direction in advance to which one can return when the mind begins to lose clarity.

Before a difficult situation, it is useful to pause briefly and recollect:

May my mind not change for the worse. I will not utter harmful words. I will wish this person well, maintaining goodwill and not nourishing inward hatred. Beginning with this person, I will extend goodwill to the whole world: vast, measureless, free from hostility and ill will.

This formula is based on [MN 21](#), where a practitioner resolves not to let the mind become corrupted, not to speak bad words, to maintain compassion, and not to nourish inward hatred.

An intention is not a promise that all subsequent events will be fully under control. Another person may behave harshly, the situation may prove more difficult than expected, and mindfulness may be lost. Practice consists in noticing the direction of the mind again and returning to the intention.

In [MN 61](#), an action is to be examined three times: before it, during it, and after it. Before acting, one may ask:

- Will this lead to harm for me?
- Will this lead to harm for another?
- Will this lead to harm for both of us?

The same question is asked during the action. Afterward, the actual consequences are assessed. If actions of body, speech, or mind have caused harm, this is to be acknowledged, examined, and not repeated.

In [MN 19](#), thoughts are divided into two directions: sensuality, ill will, and harmfulness on one side; renunciation, goodwill, and harmlessness on the other. What the mind frequently returns to gradually becomes its habitual inclination. Right intention must therefore not only be understood, but restored again and again.

The test is whether speech and action are changing, and how they affect the mind.

***Sammā-vāyāma*: Right Effort in More Detail**

Sammā-vāyāma is not a tense struggle against oneself, but the wise shaping of conditions. The classical formula is: prevent unwholesome states from arising, abandon unwholesome states that have arisen, develop wholesome states that have not yet arisen, and maintain wholesome states that have arisen.

In [SN 4.4](#), the path is compressed into two conditions: directing attention wisely and applying effort rightly. This does not replace the Eightfold Path, but reveals its heart.

[MN 2](#) shows that the taints (*āsavā*) are abandoned in different ways: by seeing, restraining, using wisely, enduring, avoiding, removing, and developing. This is an important clue: not every problem should be addressed with the same technique. Sometimes an erroneous view

must be seen; sometimes the senses restrained; sometimes an unpleasant feeling endured; sometimes a harmful situation avoided; sometimes an unwholesome thought removed; and sometimes factors of the path developed.

[MN 20](#) gives a practical sequence for working with unwholesome thoughts. If the mind is seized by sensual desire, ill will, or cruelty, one may direct attention to another wholesome object; see the danger and cost of the thought; stop feeding it with attention; examine how it is constructed and calm its formation; and, if the mind remains strongly seized, restrain it firmly. It is better to begin with the gentler methods. Harsher restraint is appropriate as a last resort.

The practical test of right effort is simple: afterward there should be less *lobha*, *dosa*, and *moha*, less inward violence, and more clarity. If effort makes the mind proud, constricted, angry, or dry, the approach should be reconsidered.

The Three Trainings

1. *sīla* - ethics. It reduces the coarse *dukkha* created through body and speech.
2. *samādhī* - collectedness. It weakens the hindrances and makes the mind fit for seeing subtle processes.
3. *paññā* - wisdom. It sees *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anattā*, and *paṭiccasamuppāda*, and ends clinging.

A Brief Path Check

Before acting, one may ask:

- Does this strengthen *lobha*, *dosa*, and *moha*, or weaken them?
- Does this make the mind clearer or more clouded?
- Does this create a story about “I” and “mine,” or release it?
- Does this lead toward simplicity or needless complication?

7. The Five Precepts: *sīla* as Training in Wisdom

The five precepts (*pañca-sīla*) are better understood not as external commandments or reasons for guilt, but as training rules (*sikkhāpada*). They help reveal which actions of body, speech, and mind lead to less harm, greater clarity, and freedom from remorse, and which nourish *lobha*, *dosa*, and *moha*.

In this sense, *sīla* is not separate from wisdom. Ethical conduct cultivates the ability to distinguish the wholesome from the unwholesome. One may know a great deal and still fail to see harm, falsehood, appropriation, violence, and carelessness. In the Dhamma, wisdom is tested not only by knowledge, but also by one’s actions.

Precept	Practical meaning	Quality disclosed
<i>Pāṇātipātā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi</i>	Abstaining from killing and intentionally causing harm.	<i>ahiṃsā, mettā</i>
<i>Adinnādānā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi</i>	Not taking what has not been given voluntarily.	<i>santutṭhi</i>
<i>Kāmesu micchācārā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi</i>	Not causing harm through sensual and sexual conduct.	<i>brahmacariya, anurakkhā</i>
<i>Musāvādā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi</i>	Abstaining from falsehood and harmful speech.	<i>sacca</i>

Precept	Practical meaning	Quality disclosed
<i>Surā-meraya-majja-pamāda-tṭhānā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi</i>	Abstaining from intoxicating substances and causes of heedlessness.	<i>appamāda</i>

Not a Commandment, but a Training Rule

A *sikkhāpada* is a rule of training. It does not say, “be perfect right now.” It indicates a direction: train conduct of body, speech, and mind that reduces harm and supports the path.

When a precept has been broken, practice does not consist in self-condemnation. It is more useful to see honestly: what condition was present, what intention stood behind the action, what the consequences were, how it affected the mind, what can be repaired, and how recurrence can be prevented.

Hiri and *ottappa*: Refraining from the Unwholesome

Hiri is moral conscience, through which an unwholesome act is seen as unworthy and incompatible with the training. *Ottappa* is caution regarding the harm that such an act may cause oneself and others. These qualities are needed to notice a dangerous direction before it becomes speech or action. In [AN 7.65](#), they are named as conditions for guarding the senses, ethical conduct, and the path.

Joy Grounded in Freedom from Remorse

The suttas say of the Dhamma that it is good in the beginning, good in the middle, and good in the end.

When precepts are kept not out of fear or guilt, and not for the image of “I am a good person,” they support freedom from remorse. Joy may gradually arise from this: the mind sees fewer defilements, less falsehood, less harshness, and less heedlessness.

The path leads to a reduction of *dukkha*, although as practice develops it may seem that there is more *dukkha*: the mind begins to notice defilements, craving, and habitual patterns that previously remained in the background. Yet the overall trend of healthy practice is less craving and *dukkha*, and greater clarity.

1. Not Causing Harm: *ahiṃsā* and *mettā*

The canonical formula of the first precept concerns intentionally depriving a living being of life. Refraining from cruelty in speech, thought, and one’s attitude toward oneself is a broader practical development of *adosa* and *mettā*; however, not every arising of anger or a harsh thought is technically a breach of the first precept.

The first precept concerns more than physical killing. Its broader meaning is not to make violence an instrument for solving problems. Violence may be expressed through body, speech, thought, one’s treatment of others, and one’s treatment of oneself.

A middle way is needed here between indulgence and self-aggression. Indulgence says, “because I want it, I may do it.” Self-aggression says, “I am bad; I must break myself.” The impulse should be seen and not fed, without hatred of oneself.

Ahiṃsā is nonviolence, including the refusal to cultivate violence in thought. *Mettā* adds a positive dimension: not merely “do no harm,” but wish for safety, freedom from hostility, and the lessening of suffering.

Check: is there an intention to cause pain or harm here? Is there revenge, irritation, or contempt? Am I turning practice into violence against myself? How can I act without *dosa*?

2. Not Taking What Is Not Given: *santuṭṭhi*

The second precept is not limited to obvious theft. It concerns everything the mind wants to appropriate without explicit permission: objects, money, time, attention, another person's labor, ideas, credit, or trust.

A subtler violation begins with the thought: "this is not mine, but it ought to be mine." Here *lobha* and the construction of "mine" can be seen. *Santuṭṭhi* is contentment, non-acquisitiveness, and freedom from appropriation.

Check: was this given voluntarily? Am I taking another person's time, attention, or labor for granted? Am I justifying appropriation with an attractive story? Where are "mine" and "I am entitled to this" operating?

A separate and subtle subject is the "theft of Dhamma": using the language, ideas, or authority of the Dhamma for status, influence, gain, or a self-image. The issue here is not copyright, but using what is sacred to feed *māna* and *bhava*.

3. Sensual and Sexual Conduct: *brahmacariya* and *anurakkhā*

For a layperson, the third precept usually means abstaining from sexual conduct that causes harm: infidelity, deception, coercion, exploitation, betrayal, using another person merely as an object for one's own pleasure, or taking advantage of weakness or lack of awareness.

In the strict sense, *brahmacariya* means celibacy or abstinence. On the monastic path, this is complete abstention from sexual conduct. For a layperson, honesty, fidelity, care, respect for boundaries, and harmlessness are important. It is therefore useful to place alongside it the word *anurakkhā*: care, protection of trust, and attentiveness in relationships.

Check: are consent, honesty, and harmlessness present? Am I using another person as a means to my pleasure? Am I rationalizing *taṇhā* with words such as "love," "it is natural," "I have the right," or "I am better, so the rules do not apply to me"?

4. Speech: *sacca*

The fourth precept is usually formulated as abstaining from falsehood, but it is useful to view speech more broadly: false speech, divisive speech, harsh speech, and idle chatter.

Falsehood is dangerous not only because it may harm someone. It damages wisdom by separating the mind from reality. Lying to others often begins with lying to oneself: excuses, rationalization, emotional reasoning, "it was not my fault," "I was forced," or "it was for the greater good."

Sacca is truthfulness. But truthfulness is not a license for harshness. Speech is examined not only for factual accuracy, but also for intention, timeliness, benefit, and harmlessness.

Check: is this a fact or my narrative? Is there an intention to deceive, embellish, conceal, or strike with words? Am I disguising harshness as "honesty"? Am I lying to myself in order to preserve the image "I am right"?

5. Sobriety: *appamāda*

The canonical formula names *surā*, *meraya*, and *majja* as a basis for *pamāda*. Applying this principle to modern drugs, psychedelics, and microdosing is an expanded practical interpretation.

The fifth precept concerns intoxicating substances and everything that becomes a basis for *pamāda*: heedlessness, distraction, and loss of vigilance. The classical formula refers primarily to substances: *surā*, *meraya*, and *majja*. In practical terms, this includes alcohol, drugs, psychedelics, and other psychoactive substances capable of causing intoxication, stupefaction, loss of control, or a noticeable impairment of clarity.

An important criterion is this: if a substance, at a plausible dose, is capable of causing intoxication or stupefaction, it falls within the scope of this precept. “Microdosing” therefore does not make a substance permissible: the precept concerns not only whether strong intoxication has occurred on a particular occasion, but also the intentional use of a substance that is a basis for *pamāda*. At small doses, intoxication may go unnoticed.

A complete breach can usually be analyzed as follows:

1. an intoxicating substance is present;
2. the person knows or understands what it is;
3. there is an intention to consume it;
4. an action is performed in order to consume it;
5. the substance enters the body;
6. there is no extreme medical necessity in which no reasonable alternative is available.

The medical exception concerns situations in which the substance is used as medicine, no better alternative is available, and refusal could cause serious harm. It is not a justification for seeking experiences, spiritual states, relaxation, or experiments with consciousness.

The point is to maintain clarity. When the mind is clouded, it becomes easier to lie, cause harm, take what is not given, or yield to sensual desire. It also obstructs meditation: *sati* becomes weaker, *samādhi* coarser, and *paññā* is more easily replaced by impressions. Unusual states or insights may sometimes occur under the influence of substances, but they are likely to be chaotic, overvalued, and not conducive to liberation.

Appamāda is sobriety, conscientiousness, attentiveness, and care. This quality guards the entire practice.

Check: does this make the mind clearer or more clouded? Does it strengthen *sati* or weaken it? Am I seeking spiritual experience through intoxication? Could this become a condition for breaking the other precepts?

Fact and Narrative

The precepts help distinguish a fact from the story by which the mind justifies an action.

- Fact: “I said something untrue.” Narrative: “I had no choice; I was forced.”
- Fact: “I took what was not given to me.” Narrative: “They already have plenty.”
- Fact: “I spoke harshly.” Narrative: “At least I was honest.”
- Fact: “I sought pleasure without considering the consequences.” Narrative: “I felt bad” or “That was how I felt.”

In this way, *sīla* becomes a practice of wise seeing: *avijjā* is already shaping a script, while *taṇhā* searches for an attractive justification.

The Precepts and Dependent Origination

A breach of a precept rarely begins with the action itself. The chain is usually visible earlier:

phassa → *vedanā* → *taṇhā* → *upādāna* → *bhava* → *kamma*.

An unpleasant feeling may become harsh speech; a pleasant one, indulgence; neutral boredom, intoxication; a sense of lack, appropriation; fear, violence. The precepts do not merely prohibit consequences. They help reveal the early conditions of action.

A Short Daily Review

At the end of the day, one may ask:

1. Where was there less harm today?
2. Where did I take what was not given?
3. Where did sensual desire begin to govern attention?
4. Where did speech distort reality?
5. Where was there heedlessness or loss of clarity?
6. Which root manifested: *lobha*, *dosa*, or *moha*?
7. Which quality should be strengthened tomorrow: *mettā*, *santutṭhi*, *anurakkhā*, *sacca*, or *appamāda*?

8. The Five *khandhā* and the Three Characteristics

The five *khandhā* are not “components of a real self,” but groups of processes to which the mind habitually clings as “I” and “mine.”

<i>Khandha</i>	What it includes	How the mind clings
<i>rūpa</i>	body, material form, elements	“my body,” “I am beautiful,” “I am ill,” “I must control the body”
<i>vedanā</i>	pleasant, unpleasant, and neutral tone	“I feel good,” “I feel bad,” “I want this feeling”
<i>saññā</i>	perception, recognition, labeling	“this is an enemy,” “this is success,” “this is mine”
<i>saṅkhārā</i>	intentions and impulses involved in shaping experience and action	“I decided,” “this is what I am like,” “this is my character”
<i>viññāṇa</i>	consciousness, awareness of an object	“I am aware,” “I am the observer,” “I am pure consciousness”

In [MN 43](#), feeling, perception, and consciousness are said to be conjoined rather than separate.

The five *khandhā* matter because they encompass the field of ordinary experience. Everything ordinarily taken as “I” or “mine” is found here: body, feeling, perception, formations, or consciousness.

The phrase “this is not mine, this I am not, this is not my self” is therefore not an invitation to seek another self beyond the aggregates. It is a way of seeing the mistaken clinging itself.

Conventional designations such as “man,” “woman,” “parent,” or “teacher” are not in themselves the problem. Clinging arises when a designation is appropriated as “I” or becomes a basis for comparison. In [SN 5.2](#), Somā rejects the idea that being a woman obstructs liberation.

Why the Five *khandhā* Are Needed When There Is *paṭiccasamuppāda*

The five *khandhā* and *paṭiccasamuppāda* answer different questions. *Paṭiccasamuppāda* shows how *dukkha* arises and ceases through conditions. The five aggregates show what the mind takes as “I” and “mine”: body, feeling, perception, formative activities, and consciousness.

The *khandhā* are therefore especially important for seeing *anattā*. They are not five parts that make up a real subject, but five processes that, under *upādāna*, become a field of appropriation. The chain shows how suffering is constructed; the aggregates show the material from which the sense of “me” is constructed.

The three characteristics, *anicca*, *dukkha*, and *anattā*, should not be turned into verbal formulas. They are to become a way of seeing.

- *anicca*: what has arisen changes, cannot be held, and disintegrates.
- *dukkha*: what changes and is not subject to control cannot be a final support.
- *anattā*: there is no independent, permanent, governing, controlling self in this.

Anattā should not be turned into the statement “I do not exist.” Nor should it be confused with depersonalization or derealization, which may involve detachment, emotional numbness, a sense of observing oneself from outside, or a sense that events are unreal. Such states are not in themselves wisdom and are not criteria of liberation.

The practical meaning of *anattā* is to see conditioned processes without appropriation: “this is not mine, this I am not, this is not my essence.” The criterion is not how unusual an experience feels, but the weakening of *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, hostility, and conceit. If a sense of unreality becomes persistent, frightening, or disruptive to ordinary life, professional help is needed rather than an attempt to deepen the state through meditation.

9. *Paṭiccasamuppāda*: the Mechanism of *dukkha*

Paṭiccasamuppāda is dependent origination: when conditions are present, a result arises; with the cessation of the conditions, the corresponding result ceases. It is neither merely a theory of rebirth nor merely a psychology of the present moment, but a way of seeing how *dukkha* is constructed when *avijjā*, *taṇhā*, and *upādāna*.

In practice, *paṭiccasamuppāda* is needed not as a philosophical map of the world, but to see where the chain is being fed and where that support can be withdrawn.

Conditions of *dukkha*

Paṭiccasamuppāda does not simply mean that “everything is connected to everything,” nor does it describe a first cause of the world. The standard formula identifies specific conditions through which *dukkha* arises and continues, and shows the cessation of the process when those conditions cease.

Beginning the sequence with *avijjā* does not make ignorance first in time. [AN 10.61](#) says that no beginning of it can be discerned, but the conditions that nourish it can be recognized.

Samāsāra is not only a cycle of birth and death. It is the entire mechanism of the twelve links: *avijjā*, *saṅkhārā*, *viññāṇa*, *nāma-rūpa*, the six sense fields, contact, feeling, craving, clinging, becoming, birth, and aging-and-death. Death does not liberate by itself: if *avijjā*, *taṇhā*, and *upādāna* remain, the dissolution of one form becomes part of further becoming.

The standard chain:

1. *avijjā* - ignorance.

2. *saṅkhārā* - formative activities.
3. *viññāṇa* - consciousness.
4. *nāma-rūpa* - name-and-form.
5. *saḷāyatana* - the six sense fields.
6. *phassa* - contact.
7. *vedanā* - feeling.
8. *taṇhā* - craving.
9. *upādāna* - clinging.
10. *bhava* - becoming: the formation and continuation of a mode of existence.
11. *jāti* - birth: the appearance of a being, the manifestation of the aggregates, and the acquisition of sense fields; on the larger scale, a new birth.
12. *jarāmaraṇa* - aging-and-death, together with sorrow, pain, dejection, and despair.

The standard sequence should not be understood as an exhaustive linear series in which each link has only one cause and one effect. In [DN 15](#), *viññāṇa* and *nāma-rūpa* are presented as mutually conditioning processes, and their connection with contact is set out differently from the standard list.

The formula is therefore a structured map of the arising of *dukkha*, not a complete diagram of all causal relations among processes.

Upādāna should not be understood merely as stronger craving. In [SN 12.2](#), craving is analyzed through the six sense fields, while clinging is analyzed through four domains: sensuality, views, rules and observances, and doctrines of self.

In practice, *upādāna* can be recognized when the mind is already holding to a pleasure, opinion, rule, or idea of oneself as “mine.”

Wholesome *saṅkhārā* as Supports for the Path

Unwholesome *saṅkhārā* directly nourish *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, *bhava*, and *dukkha*. This does not mean that every formation is simply “bad.” There are wholesome intentions, wholesome deeds, ethical conduct, generosity, mindfulness, collectedness, and wise attention. They create conditions under which the mind becomes less coarse and reactive, experiences less remorse, and more readily sees things as they are.

Yet even the wholesome can become an object of appropriation: “I am good,” “I practice,” “I attained,” “I will accumulate merit,” or “this is my state.” Wholesome qualities should therefore be developed without clinging.

Viññāṇa, *nāma-rūpa*, and *phassa*

In [SN 12.2](#), *nāma* includes feeling, perception, intention, contact, and attention, while *rūpa* consists of the four elements and the material form dependent on them.

[DN 15](#) emphasizes the mutual dependence of *viññāṇa* and *nāma-rūpa*. Consciousness is not an autonomous bearer of a self, and the psychophysical process does not unfold as a field of experience independently of the corresponding consciousness.

In [MN 148](#), the same mechanics are shown locally: a sense faculty, an object, and the corresponding *viññāṇa* meet, and from this *phassa* arises; from contact, *vedanā* arises. *Viññāṇa* among the twelve links should therefore not be understood as “awareness after contact.” Here *viññāṇa* is considered in mutual conditionality with *nāma-rūpa*, whereas MN 148 shows how contact arises in each of the six sense fields.

In [MN 38](#), the Buddha rejects the view that one and the same consciousness wanders through the round of rebirths. Consciousness arises dependently and is named after the condition

on which it arises: with the eye and forms, visual consciousness; with the ear and sounds, auditory consciousness; with the mind and mental objects, mental consciousness.

Two Scales of Reading

On the broader scale, *avijjā* and *saṅkhārā* sustain a stream that leads to new birth, aging, and death. This describes the continuation of *saṃsāra*.

In a practical analysis, the same direction can be noticed within an individual episode: contact conditions feeling; under ignorance, feeling becomes a support for craving, clinging, and a role such as “I am right,” “I am offended,” or “I must.” This role arises, changes, dissolves, and brings *dukkha*.

The language of “becoming a role” and “the birth of an offended self” is a practical analogy. It helps reveal the direction of craving and clinging in present experience, but does not replace the primary meanings of *bhava* and *jāti*.

Three Ways to Read the Chain

- **Direct reading:** shows how, in the presence of *avijjā*, one condition after another constructs *dukkha*.
- **Reverse diagnostic reading:** begins with already noticeable tension, resentment, fear, or dependence, and asks: what *bhava* is here? What is being clung to through *upādāna*? What *taṇhā* nourishes it? From what *vedanā* did it grow? What was the *phassa*?
- **Reading through cessation:** the chain is not broken by force. When a condition is recognized and not fed, the corresponding process loses its support. In a single episode, craving and clinging may cease; the complete cessation of *avijjā* is the ultimate horizon of the path.

A Liberating Chain of Conditions: from *dukkha* to *vimutti*

SN 12.23 presents not only a *saṃsāric* sequence but a liberating one. When *dukkha* is understood as the unreliability of the conditioned, it becomes an *upanisā*, a condition for turning toward the path.

Link	Practical meaning
<i>dukkha</i>	A sober recognition that conditioned experience is unreliable, not a reason for despair.
<i>saddhā</i>	Confidence: there is a path worth testing.
<i>pamojja, pīti</i>	Joy and energy arising from a wholesome direction.
<i>passaddhi, sukha</i>	Tranquility of body and mind, gentle stability.
<i>samādhi</i>	Collectedness capable of seeing subtle conditions.
<i>yathābhūtañāṇadassana</i>	Knowledge-and-vision of processes as conditioned, impermanent, unsatisfactory, and impersonal.
<i>nibbidā, virāga</i>	Disenchantment with former clinging and the fading of the coloring of experience by “I want” and “mine.”
<i>vimutti, āsavakkhayañāṇa</i>	Liberation and knowledge of the exhaustion of the <i>āsavā</i> .

In AN 11.2, the same logic is expressed through *sīla*: wholesome conduct leads to freedom from remorse (*avippaṭisāra*), then to joy, tranquility, *samādhi*, knowledge-and-vision, *nibbidā*, *virāga*, and *vimutti*. The path develops by cultivating supportive conditions, not by suppressing experience.

10. *Saṅkhārā* and *cetanā*: Where New *kamma* Arises

Saṅkhārā are formative activities. In dependent origination, arising conditioned by *avijjā*, they support the further unfolding of experience; the suttas distinguish bodily, verbal, and mental formations. As one of the five *khandhā*, the term points primarily to intentions (*cetanā*). In direct observation, their formative activity appears as impulses, tendencies, reactions, and habitual ways of responding to events. In both cases, these are conditioned formative activities, not a hidden storehouse of memories from past lives.

Kamma literally means action, but in the Dhamma it primarily means intentional action. In [AN 6.63](#), the Buddha says, “It is intention, bhikkhus, that I call *kamma*.” Having intended, one performs *kamma* through body, speech, and mind.

Kamma is not a general law of causation or a transferable “karmic force.” It is intentional action. Its ripening and result (*vipāka*) should be distinguished from the action itself.

The involuntary arising of a thought is not yet identical with an intentional mental action. In practice, it is important to recognize *cetanā*: does the mind begin to support, develop, use, or enact the arisen thought? *Kamma* can be performed through body, speech, and mind.

Phassa, or contact, is identified as a source of *kamma*. This matters for practice: intention does not appear as an independent entity. It arises within a stream of experience in which there are contact, feeling, perception, tendencies, and a state of mind. *Kamma* should therefore be seen not only after an act has been performed, but earlier, as contact begins to shape the direction of action.

The fruit of *kamma* should not be confused with all the consequences of a situation, which are produced by many conditions. An intentional action may bear fruit here and now, later in this life, or in subsequent lives. [SN 36.21](#) rejects the view that every feeling one experiences is caused solely by past *kamma*, while [MN 136](#) cautions against drawing straightforward conclusions from a single observable result.

The practical question is: what intention arose from contact, what action of body, speech, or mind follows from it, and does it lead to the weakening of greed, aversion, delusion, and clinging?

Action, Fruit, and Causal Continuity

[MN 135](#) says that beings inherit the consequences of their own actions. This should not be understood as a reference to a permanent owner, a soul, or a separate storehouse of *kamma*. The point is causality: intentional actions enter into a sequence of conditions and may bear fruit.

At the same time, no unchanging consciousness or entity passes from one birth to another. What continues is a causally conditioned process in which previous intentional actions, together with craving, clinging, and other conditions, influence subsequent arising.

In [SN 12.38](#), intention, planning, and persistent mental tendencies are shown as conditions that sustain further arising. *Cetanā* directs action and gives it kammic significance; when craving and clinging are present, such actions can sustain the continuation of becoming and birth.

How *saṅkhārā* Appear in Experience

In experience, *saṅkhārā* are often visible as an early inclination of the mind: an impulse to think, speak, act, hold on, push away, prove, hide, continue a storyline, or return to an object. This is not always coarse *taṇhā* or fully formed *upādāna*, but it is already a direction

of experience. The earlier the impulse is recognized, the less opportunity it has to solidify into speech, action, a role, and new *bhava*.

A thought should not be reduced to *saṅkhāra* alone: consciousness, perception, feeling, attention, and intention participate in it. But a thought is conditioned by formative activities and may become a new *saṅkhāra* if the mind picks it up, turns it over repeatedly, elaborates it, and appropriates it. A useful question is not “why did the thought appear?” but “what impulse wants to continue it, use it, or turn it into ‘mine’?”

Thought and *papañca*

MN 18 shows how experience becomes a basis for mental proliferation. When a faculty, an object, and the corresponding consciousness are present, *phassa* arises. In the mental sense field, mind, a thought or image, and mental consciousness together constitute *mano-samphassa*. From contact, *vedanā* arises; what is felt is perceived; what is perceived, the mind begins to think about; and what is thought about, under ignorance, proliferates into *papañca*.

Saññā marks a feature of the object: “sound,” “face,” “word,” “danger,” “pleasant.” Attention may then begin picking out details, *anuvyañjana*: tone of voice, facial expression, implication, comparison, or a past memory. If this is not recognized, *papañca* arises: a story, an argument, an image of “me,” an image of “the other,” expectation, defense, resentment, or desire.

A thought may be purely functional: remembering, speaking, going somewhere, preparing something, answering, or correcting an error. Under *avijjā*, however, a thought quickly becomes material for proliferation: “I think,” “this is my thought,” “I cannot be treated this way,” “I must prove this,” “I must hold on to this,” or “I must get rid of this.” The thought then ceases to be merely a mental event and becomes food for *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and *bhava*.

The practical question is therefore not only “what thought arose?” but also: “how does the mind pick up this thought, what colors it, and where does proliferation around ‘I,’ ‘mine,’ and ‘for me’ begin?”

Chanda is interest, desire, or intention to act. It can be wholesome when directed toward *sīla*, *sati*, *samādhi*, and *paññā*, and unwholesome when mixed with craving, self-assertion, or escape. *Taṇhā* is distinguished from wholesome *chanda* by its sense of lack, compulsion, and clinging.

A check for *saṅkhārā*: what does the mind want to do? Where is attention being drawn? What does the mind want to obtain from this thought, feeling, or situation? Are craving, fear, defense of a self-image, or control present? What conditions this, and where does “mine” arise?

The cessation of the chain does not mean the disappearance of all activities of the aggregates: the body walks, speech occurs, thoughts arise, and perception functions. But if these processes are not appropriated as “I,” they do not nourish *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and *bhava*; old conditioning is exhausted, while no new chain of suffering is built.

Two Short Examples

Criticism. An unpleasant *vedanā* may meet old *saṅkhārā*: to defend, justify, attack, fall silent. If *cetanā* is not recognized, it passes into speech, action, or an ongoing inner drama and strengthens the role “I, the offended one” or “I, the one who is right.”

Praise. A pleasant *vedanā* may meet a tendency to seek approval: “may they see me this way again.” Praise then becomes food for the image “I am valuable,” rather than simply a pleasant contact that arose and ended.

11. How *dukkha* Is Constructed from the Unpleasant

An unpleasant *vedanā* is not yet the whole of *dukkha*. Suffering is constructed when feeling becomes a condition for *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and *bhava*.

Example: a Harsh Comment

Even before the comment, *avijjā* may already be operating: a readiness to perceive experience through “me,” the need to be right, and “my worth.” The words therefore meet pre-existing tendencies.

Link	What it looks like
<i>avijjā, saṅkhārā</i>	Experience is already inclined to become personal; there are patterns of defending, attacking, justifying, and taking offense.
<i>viññāṇa, nāma-rūpa, saḷāyatana, phassa</i>	The words are heard or read, the mind recognizes their meaning, psychophysical experience takes shape, and contact occurs.
<i>vedanā</i>	An unpleasant tone: a sting, heat, fear, irritation.
<i>taṇhā</i>	“I want to remove this,” “I want to prove it,” “I want to reassert that I am right.”
<i>upādāna, bhava</i>	Clinging to an image and becoming a role: the defender, the offended one, the judge, the victim.
<i>jāti, jarāmaraṇa</i>	The “I who was insulted” is born; the role ages through replaying, exhaustion, guilt, or conflict.

Practice does not turn the unpleasant into the pleasant. It recognizes: “an unpleasant feeling arose through conditions; it does not have to become my story.”

12. How *dukkha* Is Constructed from the Pleasant and the Neutral

A pleasant feeling is not in itself unwholesome. Under *avijjā*, however, it easily becomes a support for “I” and “mine.”

The Pleasant: Praise

Phassa: words of praise are heard, or an approving message arrives. *Vedanā*: warmth, joy, lightness. *Taṇhā*: “I want more,” “may they see me this way.” *Upādāna*: “this proves that I am valuable.” *Bhava* and *jāti*: a “successful self,” a “loved self,” or a “practitioner self” is born. When the praise ends, the image has to be maintained, and anxiety, comparison, or fear of loss arises.

A wise response is to know the contact, the pleasant *vedanā*, and the possible craving without turning a pleasant experience into a personal biography. A pleasant feeling can simply be pleasant without being turned into “mine,” “let it remain,” or “I must hold on to this.” It is important to see when it becomes food for *taṇhā*.

Neutral *vedanā*: a Hidden Support for *avijjā*

Neutral *vedanā* is not the absence of feeling, but the tone arising from contact that is experienced as neither clearly pleasant nor clearly unpleasant. MN 148 says that the pleasant can nourish the underlying tendency (*anusaya*) to passion, the unpleasant the underlying tendency to aversion, and the neutral, when its arising, cessation, gratification, danger, and conditioned nature are not understood, the underlying tendency to ignorance.

Vedanā itself is not yet craving, aversion, or ignorance. But if the feeling is not clearly understood, the corresponding underlying tendency may manifest: passion toward the pleasant, aversion toward the unpleasant, or ignorance regarding the neutral.

It is therefore important to notice the background of experience: clothing touching the skin, the pressure of the body on a chair, body temperature, the sensation of satiety, sounds from the street, thoughts, plans, and so forth. Pay particular attention to *mano-samphassa*: a thought is also an object of contact and produces *vedanā*. The neutral may provoke either a search for stimulation (“this is boring; I need to turn something on”) or fixation (“I will remain in this even state”). In both cases, *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and *bhava* can be observed.

Neutral *vedanā* should not be confused with *upekkhā*: neutral feeling can be a dull background, whereas *upekkhā* as a factor of the path is clear, sober, and does not obstruct right action.

Checking the Pleasant and the Neutral

What was the *phassa*? What *vedanā* arose? Is there “I want more,” “I want to remove this,” or “I want to fill the background”? What image is being held through *upādāna*? What mode of *bhava* is taking shape? What will the dissolution of this state be like?

13. Where the Chain Can Be Interrupted

It is not necessary to catch the very first moment of *avijjā*. The chain can be weakened at different points. It is not broken by force. More precisely, when conditions are recognized and no longer fed, the process loses its support and gradually ceases. Practice consists not in suppression, but in clearly seeing exactly where *taṇhā* receives nourishment.

Where it was noticed	What can be done
At <i>phassa</i>	Slow down: “there was contact.” Do not add a story immediately.
At <i>vedanā</i>	Name the tone: pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral. Feel the body.
At <i>taṇhā</i>	See the promise: “if I get/remove this, things will be good.”
At <i>upādāna</i>	Find what the mind is holding to: being right, an image, safety, recognition, control.
At <i>bhava</i>	Recognize the role: the offended one, defender, winner, victim, controller, practitioner.
After <i>jāti</i>	Acknowledge: “the role has already been born.” Do not feed it through speech, action, and repetition.
At <i>jarāmarāṇa</i>	See the cost: exhaustion, guilt, anxiety, dependence, replaying.

Even if *taṇhā* has already arisen, this is not a failure. Even if *upādāna* has begun, this is not the end of practice. What matters more than catching it perfectly early is ending further nourishment.

14. Desire: Do Not Indulge or Suppress It, but Understand It

Desire does not have to be automatically fulfilled. But it should not be crushed either. Suppression often creates an inner dam: prohibition on the surface, accumulated tension underneath. Sooner or later, it bursts.

Three modes:

1. **Indulgence.** A desire arises and is immediately fulfilled. The mind learns that every *vedanā* must be prolonged or removed.
2. **Suppression.** A desire arises and is squeezed, condemned, forbidden. The desire is not understood, but driven underground and into shadow.
3. **Not feeding *taṇhā*.** Desire is seen as a process: bodily impulse, image, promise, thought, tension. It can be lived through without automatic fulfillment and without inner conflict.

The struggle against craving easily becomes another form of craving: craving for control, craving to conquer oneself, or craving for non-existence. It is therefore more useful to see the conditions of desire, its flavor, its cost, and the point where it is nourished.

***Vedanā* Is Not a Reaction**

Vedanā is not an emotion and not a story about what is happening, but the tone of experience: pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral. Emotion usually arises further along, when the mind begins to react to this tone.

An emotion is usually broader than *vedanā*. Perception, intention, bodily tension, a story, and the state of mind already participate in it. An unpleasant tone of contact is therefore not yet anger, but under ignorance it may quickly become a role: “I am offended,” “I am defending myself,” “I must respond.”

A pleasant feeling easily becomes a condition for “I want more.” An unpleasant one becomes a condition for “remove, reject, destroy.” The neutral is often barely noticed and becomes a condition for boredom, fixation, or the search for a more vivid object.

Practice begins by recognizing feeling as feeling: pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral, arisen through conditions. Such recognition makes it possible to notice the subsequent reaction, but does not by itself end *taṇhā*. As understanding becomes clearer and guarding the sense doors, right effort, mindfulness, collectedness, and wisdom grow stronger, the mind clings to the pleasant, resists the unpleasant, and overlooks the neutral less and less.

How the Chain Unfolds Differently

The ordinary chain proceeds quickly: contact, feeling, craving, clinging, becoming, and *dukkha*. Practice does not destroy contact or feeling. It changes what happens after feeling.

When there are *sati*, clear comprehension, and collectedness, feeling can be recognized as feeling. Instead of the automatic “I want,” “I do not want,” or “I do not notice,” clear seeing becomes possible: this arose through conditions, changes, and is not “mine.” The link between *vedanā* and *taṇhā* is thereby weakened, and the mind develops an inclination toward letting go.

How to Investigate Sensual Pleasure

Guarding the sense doors is not reducible to avoiding attractive objects or suppressing reactions. With contact, pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral *vedanā* arises. Under *avijjā*, feeling may become a condition for *taṇhā*: the mind demands that the pleasant be prolonged, the unpleasant removed, or the neutral background filled.

In [AN 6.63](#), *kāma* is explained not as attractive objects themselves, but as the desire and passion directed toward them.

In [MN 13](#), sensual experience is investigated from three sides:

assāda - gratification, pleasure, and joy,
ādīnava - danger, unreliability, and cost,
nissaraṇa - escape through abandoning desire and passion.

The aim is not to convince oneself that a pleasant object is actually unpleasant. Gratification is to be known as gratification. At the same time, it is important to see what conditions it depends upon, how quickly it changes, what the mind demands after it ends, and what the cost of repetition is.

It is especially important to notice that sensual pleasure is often used not for the sake of the object itself, but as an anesthetic for unpleasant *vedanā*: fatigue, loneliness, anxiety, boredom, or inner tension. The practical question is then not only “what do I want?” but also “what state is the mind trying to numb with this?”

In a particular episode, the way out may involve pausing, changing the conditions, meeting the actual need in another way, using the object in moderation, or completely abstaining. The deeper way out is that desire and passion lose their power, while pleasant feeling no longer demands continuation, repetition, or retention.

Metaphors for *taṇhā*

The suttas often explain *taṇhā* through images. It frequently appears as a habit, “just a little more,” fear of loss, a wish to repeat, a wish to become someone, or a wish that something not exist.

In [Dhp 334](#), craving is compared to a creeping vine: in a heedless person it grows. In the same way, a small concession, if unseen, gradually becomes a direction of mind. A person seized by craving is then compared to a monkey seeking fruit: the mind leaps from one object to another, hoping to find satisfaction somewhere farther on.

In [Dhp 335–336](#), craving is linked to the image of grass that grows again after rain. The outward manifestation can be cut down, but if the root is not recognized, the tendency sprouts again when suitable conditions appear. Practice therefore works not only with the action, but also with *vedanā*, *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and the mind’s latent readiness to follow the same familiar route again.

In [SN 35.28](#), the Buddha says that the six sense fields, contact, and feelings burn with the fires of greed, hatred, and delusion. Pleasant feeling promises warmth, but when fed by clinging it becomes fuel for craving. What is seen, heard, sensed, and thought then becomes fuel for “I want,” “I do not want,” “may it be mine,” and “may it disappear.”

In [AN 6.61](#), craving is called a seamstress. It stitches separate contacts, feelings, memories, and expectations into a story: “this is me,” “this is mine,” “I was like this,” “I will be like this.” A fabric of *bhava* is thus woven from separate conditioned processes.

In [MN 75](#), indulging sensual craving is compared to scratching itchy sores. Scratching brings brief relief, but damages the wounds and strengthens the need to scratch again. Likewise, a pleasant object may genuinely give pleasure or temporarily relieve tension, but it does not remove craving and may strengthen tendencies.

In [Dhp 347](#), beings carried away by passion are compared to a spider caught in its own web. The mind itself weaves expectations, roles, fears, and attachments, and then suffers within

what it has constructed.

In SN 36.6, painful feeling is compared to a first dart, and mental suffering to a second. This shows that pain and *dukkha* are not the same. The first dart may arise through conditions, but the second is created by resistance, craving, and mental proliferation.

In SN 35.63, it is said that if craving has not been abandoned, it remains a companion even for one who has gone to the forest. Seclusion by itself therefore does not liberate: one may be physically alone and still live together with craving.

These metaphors point to one thing: *taṇhā* does not cease through satiation. It loses strength when its conditions, its flavor, its danger, and the ways of letting it go are seen.

Example: a Chocolate Bar

Contact: seeing a chocolate bar or remembering its taste.

Vedanā: a pleasant feeling connected with anticipation arises.

Taṇhā: “I want to get it,” “I want comfort,” “I want a reward.”

Upādāna: “I need this,” “I deserve it,” “the evening is not right without it.”

Bhava: “I, the one who needs something pleasant,” “I, the tired one entitled to a reward,” or, conversely, “I, the practitioner who must not want.”

Jarāmarāṇa: the pleasure will end; heaviness, guilt, desire for more, irritation, or renewed tension around control may follow.

The practical choice may differ. Sometimes one may calmly eat a little, without the myth “this will save me.” Sometimes it is better not to eat, because it is clear that this is an attempt to cover fatigue, anxiety, or boredom. The problem is not the chocolate, but the chain:

pleasant feeling → “I need it” → “I cannot do without it” → “I must get it.”

Three sides of the experience can be distinguished here.

Assāda: the chocolate really has a pleasant taste and provides pleasure and brief relief.

Ādīnava: the pleasure ends quickly and does not fully remove the fatigue, anxiety, boredom, or dissatisfaction from which the mind was trying to escape. If the pattern repeats, the mind memorizes the path and a habit forms. New craving, heaviness, guilt, or a struggle against oneself is added to the initial tension.

Nissaraṇa: seeing the demand and not indulging it automatically. Pleasant feeling arises and ends. The unpleasant can be experienced directly without an immediate attempt to numb it. If the body genuinely needs food, water, or rest, the need is met calmly, without turning it into a reward, salvation, or confirmation of a self-image.

15. Satipaṭṭhāna: the Four Establishments of Mindfulness

Satipaṭṭhāna is not the observation of “everything indiscriminately,” but clear mindfulness of body, feeling, mind, and *dhammā* as arising, conditioned, and impersonal processes. This practice operates within the integrated path: *sīla*, *indriya-saṃvara*, *sati*, *samādhi*, and *paññā* support one another.

Sati itself is also conditioned: it arises, strengthens, and weakens depending on causes such as *sīla*, energy, clarity, collectedness, wise attention, and the absence of coarse hindrances. Awakening does not mean permanent “24/7 awareness” as an unchanging state. More

important is that experience is no longer appropriated as “I” and no longer feeds *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and *bhava*.

Establishment	Practice	Error
<i>kāyānupassanā</i>	Body as body: breathing, postures, elements, actions, dissolution.	“This is my body, and I must constantly subject it to my will.”
<i>vedanānupassanā</i>	Pleasant, unpleasant, and neutral <i>vedanā</i> .	Immediately turning feeling into a story, or romanticizing it.
<i>cittānupassanā</i>	Mind with or without craving, with or without hatred, collected or distracted.	Creating an “observer self.”
<i>dhammānupassanā</i>	The hindrances, <i>khandhā</i> , sense fields, <i>bojjhaṅgā</i> , and <i>ariyasacca</i> .	Theorizing instead of recognizing.

The formula “body as body” points to contemplation of a specific aspect of bodily experience, such as breathing, posture, parts of the body, or elements. In [MN 118](#), breathing is treated as a bodily process. It can therefore be observed as a distinct object of body contemplation; it is not necessary to encompass every bodily sensation simultaneously.

In contemplation of feelings, one distinguishes not only pleasant, unpleasant, and neutral *vedanā*, but also the conditions in which it arose: whether it is connected with sensual attraction or with renunciation. The pleasant or unpleasant tone by itself does not yet show the direction in which the mind is moving. A pleasant feeling may accompany clinging, or it may arise together with calming. An unpleasant feeling likewise does not by itself determine the direction of mind: it may accompany aversion, or it may arise in the course of renunciation or practice.

Having recognized the feeling, it is useful to notice whether *taṇhā* follows it, or whether the mind is capable of not clinging and inclines toward letting go.

Dhammānupassanā is contemplation of *dhammā* as *dhammā*: hindrances, factors of awakening, and other practical categories of the Dhamma. One recognizes not only whether the relevant phenomenon is present, but also the conditions of its arising and cessation. In the case of a hindrance, one investigates what feeds it and what leads to its abandonment; in the case of a factor of awakening, what promotes its arising and further development.

Observing *citta*

In observing the mind, it is important to see not so much the content of thoughts as the state of mind. Mind with craving or without craving, with aversion or without aversion, with delusion or without delusion, collected or distracted, contracted or expansive, liberated or not liberated.

Practice thereby avoids becoming an analysis of the story. Instead of “why am I thinking about this again?” one may see: the mind is now irritated; the mind now has desire; the mind is confused; the mind has become gentler. This returns attention to conditions rather than to the plot.

Practices of *satipaṭṭhāna*

[MN 10](#) and [DN 22](#) list breathing, postures, clear comprehension of actions, parts of the

body, elements, cemetery contemplations, feelings, states of mind, and *dhammā*. Their task is to teach one to see body as body, feeling as feeling, mind as mind, and phenomena as phenomena, without appropriation.

It is useful to distinguish directed contemplation from open practice. In the first, attention remains with one field: breathing, elements, *vedanā*, mind, or *dhammā*. In the second, once the mind is stable, processes may appear within a broad field: sound, sensation, thought, feeling, intention. The criterion is the same: are arising, cessation, conditionality, and non-appropriation visible?

The Body as Elements

One way to practice *anattā* is to contemplate the body as elements. The body is seen not as “my body,” but as an interaction of earth, water, heat, and air: solidity, fluidity, temperature, movement. This is not the concept “I know that the body consists of elements,” but a direct investigation of bodily experience in which no owner is found.

Contemplating the Body, Its Parts, the Elements, and Death Without Aversion

Contemplation of body parts, elements, and death is not intended to produce disgust toward the body or gloom. Its purpose is sobriety. The body is seen as body: composite, dependent, vulnerable, and not fully subject to will. This weakens enchantment, fear, and appropriation, but should not turn into aversion. Such practices also often help calm the mind at the beginning of meditation.

Walking Meditation

Walking meditation (*caṅkama*) is not a secondary practice, but a natural continuation of *kāyānupassanā*. [MN 10](#) and [DN 22](#) say explicitly: when a practitioner is walking, they know, “I am walking”; when standing, sitting, or lying down, they know the corresponding bodily posture. Walking helps carry *sati* from motionless sitting into movement and daily life. It is also useful when there is drowsiness, heaviness after eating, or bodily discomfort.

A practical method:

- choose a level path or quiet area with few distractions;
- before beginning, align the body for a moment and establish the intention;
- walk at a natural pace, without turning walking into theatrical slowness;
- keep attention on sensations in the feet and legs, on the movement of the body as a whole, or on breathing; choose what works best;
- when the mind wanders into thought, gently notice this and return to the step;
- see walking as a process: lifting, moving, touching, pressure, shifts of balance, and the intention to walk.

Walking provides a clear way to observe *anattā*: steps occur through many conditions, including intention, balance, muscles, contact with the ground, attention, and habit. No owner can be found in a step; there are conditions, a conditioned process, movement, and knowing movement.

***Sati-sampajañña*: Mindfulness and Clear Comprehension**

In the standard formula of *satipaṭṭhāna*, the practitioner is described as *ātāpī sampajāno satimā*: diligent, clearly comprehending, mindful.

Ātāpī means diligent and ardent. The word is literally associated with heat or burning, but here it is better understood as bright, sustained energy: not becoming distracted, not feeding the unwholesome, and maintaining the conditions for clarity.

Sati is mindfulness or recollection: the ability to remember the object, task, and direction of practice and, when distraction is noticed, return to them.

Sampajañña means clear comprehension: what is happening now, why an action is being performed, whether it is appropriate, and what consequences may follow.

Mindfulness does not require holding to an object at all costs while ignoring what is happening around one. In formal meditation and daily activity, the object and breadth of attention are chosen according to the task and conditions.

As practice deepens, the conditionality, impermanence, and impersonal nature of what is happening become clearer.

***Sati* and Sensual Desire**

The arising of sensual desire does not yet mean that mindfulness is completely absent. In [MN 10](#), the practitioner recognizes the presence or absence of *kāmacchanda*, the conditions of its arising, its abandonment, and its future non-arising.

Recognizing desire and following it are not the same. Right mindfulness does not make indulgence in sensuality part of practice. In [SN 47.5](#), the five hindrances, including sensual desire, are called a mass of the unwholesome, while the four establishments of mindfulness are called a mass of the wholesome.

In [MN 22](#), the monk Aritṭha claims that phenomena called obstructions do not obstruct one who indulges in them. The Buddha rejects this view and emphasizes the danger of sensual pleasures. Observing desire with mindfulness therefore cannot be confused with justifying or consciously feeding it: *sammā-sati* and indulgence in sensual craving direct the mind in opposite directions.

Right Observation and *anattā*

It is useful, but insufficient, merely to see “it came and went.” Right observation asks: was there *phassa*? What *vedanā* arose? Is there *taṇhā*? Is there *upādāna*? What mode of *bhava* is taking shape? Can this chain be left unfed?

The word “observe” is conventional. It should not be turned into a separate witness: “I am the one who is aware,” “I am the one who sees processes.” Nor does *anattā* mean the position “I do not exist.” Ideas such as “I understood that I do not exist,” “I observe the absence of self,” or “I do not exist, therefore anything is permitted” may still be subtle *bhava*.

In practice, *anattā* is disclosed in this way: a process is known as a process. There are conditions, contact, feeling, craving, clinging, and becoming. When this is clearly seen as composite, conditioned, impermanent, and subject to dissolution, the mind ceases to build “I” and “mine” around the process.

This is especially important with thoughts. A thought is also *mano-samphassa*: it gives rise to *vedanā*, after which the mind may want to obtain, prove, hold, calm, or elaborate something. The question is: “what does the mind want to obtain through this thought?” When this is seen, the thought ceases to be “mine” and is seen as a conditioned process.

Sense Fields, Feeling, and Story

In daily life, it is useful to return to the simplest map of experience: through which door did contact arise, and what tone of feeling appeared? The mind then sees experience before a story grows around it. Instead of “he insulted me,” one may notice hearing, unpleasant feeling, aversion, and the impulse to respond. *Papañca* thereby receives less nourishment.

Thinking can itself be attractive. Planning, fantasy, argument, inner commentary, and memory create a sense of movement. This movement may be pleasant or stimulating, and the mind seeks it again. It is therefore important to see not only the content of thought, but also the feeling that arises through contact with it.

How the Defiled Mind Works

The activity of a defiled mind can be described as follows. It receives a signal, recognizes it, connects it with memory, gives it a name, adds an evaluation, colors experience with pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral feeling, and then constructs a story of “I” and “mine.”

When ignorance is present, this story is mistaken for reality. When craving is present, the mind wants to retain the pleasant, remove the unpleasant, or find a new stimulus. When clinging is present, the story proliferates. When becoming is present, a role takes shape: “this is what I am,” “I must,” “I attained,” “I lost,” “I exist.”

Thus the mind does not merely reflect experience; it sustains the chain of *dukkha*.

A Method for Working with a Restless Mind

When the mind is restless, it often tries to calm itself by thinking even more. One thought arises, then another, followed by a plan, an argument, a memory, a fantasy, an explanation, or a dialogue. It seems that with just a little more thinking, the mind will finally find safety, control, or a solution. Often, however, this merely continues the chain.

Such a stream of thought can be understood as *mano-samphassa*: a thought, image, plan, or memory becomes an object of mental contact. From that contact, *vedanā* necessarily arises; the mind may then want to continue the thought, remove it, prove something, console itself with it, or construct a new role from it.

A practical sequence:

1. Slow down and acknowledge: “mental contact has arisen.”
2. Recognize *vedanā*: pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral feeling.
3. See the thought as a thought: an image, phrase, scenario, or inner argument.
4. Ask: what does the mind want to obtain from this thought?
5. Find *taṇhā*: the desire to solve, retain, prove, control, remove, or fill emptiness.
6. Find *upādāna*: what the mind holds as “mine” - being right, an image, safety, a plan, anxiety, or the role of a practitioner.
7. Recognize *bhava*: what kind of “I” is taking shape - “anxious me,” “controlling me,” “me who must finish thinking this through,” “offended me,” or “the practitioner me whose thoughts are interfering.”
8. Do not feed the chain further: gently return to the body, breathing, the step, *mettā*, or apply one of the methods in [MN 20](#).

The task is not to switch off thoughts or force the mind to become empty. The desire to get rid of thoughts can itself be *taṇhā*. Practice consists in seeing how a thought becomes food for craving, clinging, and becoming, and ceasing to nourish that process.

Mental contact may also take images, fantasies, memories, or a song or melody stuck in the mind as its object.

16. *Nīvaraṇa* and *bojjhaṅgā*: Diagnosis and Balance

The five *nīvaraṇa* obstruct clarity. The seven *bojjhaṅgā* support progress on the path. It is useful to understand what is happening in the mind.

A hindrance is better seen not as “my problem,” but as a conditioned process. It is important to notice whether it is present now, how it arose, what sustains it, under what conditions it weakens, and what helps prevent its future arising. Working with hindrances then becomes not a struggle against oneself, but an investigation of conditions.

Diagnosis: Seeing What Is Present and What Is Absent

Work with the *nīvaraṇa* begins with honest recognition. In [MN 5](#), it is emphasized that it is worse to have a stain and not recognize it than to have a stain and recognize it, because seeing it makes removal possible. The same applies to the hindrances: sensual desire, irritation, dullness, restlessness, or doubt must first be recognized as present.

But it is also important to see when a hindrance is absent. Otherwise the mind may again carelessly follow an attractive, irritating, or clouding object. It is therefore useful not only to ask, “which hindrance is present now?” but also to notice, “this hindrance is absent now; what conditions led to its arising, weakening, or absence?”

In [MN 9](#), right view is explained as understanding a phenomenon, its arising, its cessation, and the way leading to its cessation. The same scheme can be applied to the hindrances: what has arisen now, from what conditions, how it ceases, and what factor supports its non-arising.

How to Work with the Five *nīvaraṇa*

The five *nīvaraṇa* arise not only in meditation. They may obstruct clarity in conversation, work, study, and decision-making. In [AN 5.51](#), they are called obstructions of the mind that weaken wisdom and make it difficult to choose wisely for oneself and others.

In contemplation of *dhammā*, it is important to see whether a hindrance is present now; when it is absent, which conditions sustain that absence; how an unarisen hindrance arises; how an arisen hindrance is abandoned; and how an extinguished hindrance is not fed again.

A hindrance need not be defeated through forceful effort. It is often more useful to see what feeds it and stop providing that nourishment.

Hindrance	How it manifests	What to do
<i>kāmacchanda</i> - sensual desire	The mind is drawn to a pleasant image, taste, bodily sensation, fantasy, or plan for pleasure. The object appears to promise happiness.	See the attractive image as an image. Recognize <i>vedanā</i> and craving. Reduce sensual nourishment and gently return to breathing or the body. <i>Asubha</i> , contemplation of the impermanence of the pleasant, and restraint of the sense faculties may be useful.

<i>vyāpāda</i> - ill will	The mind argues, accuses, rejects, wants to punish, prove, or get rid of something. Sometimes ill will is directed not at a person but at the meditation object itself: breathing has become tiresome, the body is irritating, or practice seems boring or unbearable.	Recognize unpleasant <i>vedanā</i> and the wish to push away. Calm the body, breathing, and face. Develop <i>mettā</i> . If the irritation is directed at breathing, there is no need to force oneself to “endure the object”: one may gently find a pleasant, beautiful, calming, or subtler aspect of the breath, expand attention to the whole body, or temporarily shift to <i>mettā</i> . If there is an unresolved conflict, one may calmly note: “I will deal with this after meditation.”
<i>thīna-middha</i> - dullness and drowsiness	Cloudiness, heaviness, sinking, drowsiness, loss of clarity.	Check whether this is bodily fatigue or mental dullness. Sit more upright, open or half-open the eyes, and feel the whole body. At this stage the mind is often quite pliable: merely remembering or saying the word “clarity” may help. Light, walking, investigation of <i>dhammā</i> , inspiration, <i>pīti</i> , <i>sukha</i> , recollection of the Buddha, and recollection of the aims of practice may be useful. If the body is genuinely exhausted or sleep-deprived, rest or sleep appropriately. It is important to feel what is needed. Often, simply sitting more upright is enough.
<i>uddhacca-kukkucca</i> - restlessness and remorse	The mind leaps, plans, checks, argues, and searches for guarantees. With remorse, it returns again and again to what was done or left undone.	Simplify the task: only the body, only the breath, only this step. Be content with what is already here and now. Develop <i>passaddhi</i> , <i>samādhi</i> , and <i>upekkhā</i> . If there was a real mistake, acknowledge it, resolve to repair what can be repaired at an appropriate time, and release the replaying. A restless thought can be examined through <i>phassa</i> , <i>vedanā</i> , <i>taṇhā</i> , <i>upādāna</i> , and <i>bhava</i> .

vicikicchā - doubt

“Am I doing this correctly?” “Is this the right method?” “Does it make sense?” “Perhaps I need something else?” Doubt paralyzes practice.

Distinguish useful investigation from doubt that drains energy. Apply *yoniso manasikāra*: what is unwholesome now, what is wholesome, and what leads to the cessation of *dukkha*? After the session, one may consult the suttas, ask an experienced practitioner, or clarify the method. During the session, do not feed doubt or doubt about the doubt itself; observe and let go.

Hindrances do not always appear one at a time. In a single episode the body may be heavy and drowsy while the mind is simultaneously restless, irritated, or seeking stimulation. This is not a new hindrance, but a combination of signs whose conditions should be investigated separately.

The antidote is therefore not selected by a single label: the body may need movement and light, while the mind needs less stimulation and a softening of irritation.

Restlessness itself can become an object of practice. Instead of analyzing each storyline, it is useful to recognize the quality of mind and its bodily manifestations: inner agitation, tension, an impulse to switch objects immediately, or to continue thinking. One can then investigate what feeds this state and what happens when the impulse is not followed.

The general criterion is this: if the chosen response leaves less *lobha*, *dosa*, and *moha*, less contraction, and more clarity, the direction is sound. If practice makes the mind rigid, proud, clouded, or anxious, the conditions and the manner of effort should be examined.

Important: use an antidote when it is needed, and set it aside once the hindrance has subsided. Discern what is most appropriate now.

Balance and the Seven *bojjhaṅgā*

Sati is always needed: without mindfulness, the mind notices neither a hindrance nor its absence, nor the factors of the path.

When the mind is heavy, clouded, or sleepy, activating factors are usually helpful: *dharmavicaya*, *virīya*, and *pīti*. One may sit more upright, open or half-open the eyes, feel the whole body, switch to walking, recollect the aim of practice, or recollect the goodness of the Dhamma.

When the mind is overexcited, anxious, argumentative, or continually replaying thoughts, calming factors are usually helpful: *passaddhi*, *samādhi*, and *upekkhā*. Breathing, the whole body, slowing down, simplicity, *mettā*, and reducing incoming stimulation can help.

When the mind clings to the pleasant, it is important to see the pleasant as arisen through conditions, impermanent, and impersonal. Pleasant feeling itself is not the problem; the problem begins where it becomes a promise of happiness and food for *taṇhā*.

If body and mind genuinely need rest, one should not torment oneself with practice. It is probably better to rest or sleep peacefully. But rest should also be wise: do not keep

bombarding the mind with social-media feeds, short videos, arguments, or other stimulation; give body and mind genuine restoration.

17. *Mettā, asubha, indriya-saṃvara, and yoniso manasikāra*

Mettā

Mettā is goodwill or loving-kindness. It softens the mind, reduces *dosa*, and makes practice less dry. To prevent *mettā* from becoming a new identity, “I am kind,” or a way of controlling everything through gentleness, it too should be seen as a conditioned and interdependent process.

A short practice:

- May this being be safe.
- May this being be free from hostility.
- May this being be free from suffering.
- May this being live in well-being, as far as possible.

There is no need to force a special feeling out of oneself. One may relate to the body, breathing, sounds, other people, and the world without hostility or a drive to control them. Toward living beings, one may cultivate wishes for safety and freedom from suffering. Any gentleness and warmth that arise can be sustained as part of *mettā*, but not turned into a metaphysical entity or “my experience.”

In the practice of *mettā*, it is important not to forget oneself. This is not about self-centeredness or strengthening an image of “me,” but about oneself as a living being who is also subject to pain, fear, fatigue, and suffering, and who also needs goodwill.

Dosa and adosa

Hostility does not cease by adding more hostility. This only feeds the chain: contact becomes unpleasant feeling, unpleasant feeling becomes rejection, and rejection becomes harsh speech, action, or conflict.

*Na hi verena verāṇi, sammantīdha kudācanarū;
Averena ca sammanti, esa dhammo sanantano.*

[Dhp 5](#) says that hostility is not stilled by hostility (*verena*); it is stilled by non-hostility (*averena*). This clearly shows the practical meaning of *adosa*. The point is not to approve of everything or become helpless, but not to feed *dosa* with new *dosa*. Action may sometimes need to be firm, but the mind does not have to become hostile.

In [SnP 1.8](#), the same principle is expressed practically: do not deceive, despise, or wish suffering upon another out of anger and rejection.

Asubha

Asubha does not mean hatred of the body. It is a sober seeing of the body as body: elements, processes, aging, illness, dissolution. The practice is useful against sensual enchantment and the idealization of form.

Indriya-saṃvara

Restraint of the sense faculties is not hatred of the world, but wise restraint in what one takes in through the senses. If the mind is constantly fed hyperstimulation, content, arguments, news, and gossip, *taṇhā* receives endless food.

If the mind is already caught, one may look away, close an app, end a conversation, or stop elaborating mental imagery. This is not necessarily suppression. Sometimes changing external conditions is the wisest and simplest way to prevent the chain from receiving new nourishment.

Practice includes:

- noticing which signs and details seize attention again;
- not developing fantasy, inner argument, or the search for the next stimulus;
- reducing unnecessary incoming contacts that feed craving and irritation;
- pausing before responding;
- setting aside screen-free periods of silence.

Yoniso manasikāra

In [MN 2](#), wise attention is connected with the non-arising of new taints and the abandonment of those already arisen. In [SN 46.51](#), frequent attention to particular signs is called nourishment for the corresponding hindrances or factors of awakening.

Attention is therefore better understood not as a universal “fuel of mind,” but as a condition that strengthens the chosen direction. As a practical distinction, one may say that *sati* helps one not lose the object, task, and framework of practice, while *yoniso manasikāra* directs examination toward causes, consequences, and cessation: not “how can I obtain what I want?” but “what conditions are creating *dukkha* now, and which lead to its cessation?”

18. *Samādhi* and the Jhānas

Samādhi is not for accumulating spiritual experiences; it is for making the mind fit for its work. A collected mind is less disturbed by the *nīvaraṇa* and better able to see the sequence *vedanā - taṇhā - upādāna - bhava*. *Samatha* calms and collects the mind; *vipassanā* clarifies conditions and dispels *avijjā*. Without wisdom, even deep peace may become subtle clinging.

Samatha and *vipassanā* are not two competing paths. In [AN 4.170](#), four possibilities are described: insight preceded by tranquility; tranquility preceded by insight; their development in tandem; and a case in which the mind is initially seized by agitation concerning the Dhamma, but then becomes steady, settles, unifies, and concentrates.

In every case, the criterion is the arising and development of the path, the abandoning of fetters, and the eradication of underlying tendencies.

***Sammā-samādhi* and the Other Factors of the Path**

In [MN 117](#), noble right collectedness is described as collectedness of mind supported by the other seven factors of the path: right view, intention, speech, action, livelihood, effort, and mindfulness.

Right collectedness is defined not merely by the depth or stability of a state, but by its development within the surrounding factors of the Noble Path and by its service in abandoning unwholesome states and developing liberating wisdom.

Samatha is better understood not as tightly compressed attention, but as calming and purifying *citta*. The hindrances make the mind coarse, agitated, heavy, or clouded; *samatha* gradually weakens this pressure.

Right collectedness is therefore neither drowsiness nor pleasant oblivion. It must combine gentle calming with wakeful clarity. If calm leads to fixation, loss of clarity, and unwillingness to see conditions, it is not yet the collectedness that supports wisdom.

What Changes at the Level of Mind

The practice of *samādhi* helps one see mind as a conditioned process. In an ordinary state, it seems that “my mind” is simply like this: anxious, heavy, clear, sleepy, or restless. In practice, however, it becomes noticeable that the state of mind changes according to conditions.

The mind can be collected or uncollected, clear or clouded, gentle or tense, calm or agitated. Practice helps reveal that mind is not a permanent self or an owner of experience. It too arises, changes, and calms depending on causes.

When the mind is collected, contact becomes less chaotic, feelings are recognized more clearly, and the link *vedanā - tanhā* is not triggered so sharply. Collectedness is therefore needed not for the sake of possessing a state, but to make the mind fit to see.

Jhāna as a Condition for Seeing

Samādhi is useful because the mind becomes collected, less seized by hindrances, and capable of seeing subtle phenomena. Without sufficient collectedness, the mind retains blind spots: the hindrances not only distort perception, but conceal their own influence. Jhāna does not guarantee wisdom, but the temporary abandonment of hindrances makes the mind fitter for clear investigation of experience.

Jhāna remains a conditioned process. Its factors arise through conditions and cease through conditions. Even deep *samādhi* should therefore be seen in terms of *anicca*, *dukkha*, and *anattā*. If an image is built around jhāna, such as “I attained,” “I am special,” or “I must hold on to this,” it becomes food for *upādāna*, *māna*, and *bhava*.

How to Approach Jhāna

Jhāna (*jhāna*) is not attained through tension. In practice, entry begins with *sīla*, *sati*, the temporary fading of the five *nīvaraṇa*, and a calm support such as breathing or the body. Seclusion in the formula of the first jhāna is not only physical but inward: the mind stops feeding sensual desire, irritation, dullness, restlessness, and doubt.

In *ānāpānasati*, the task is not to control breathing, but clearly to know inhalation and exhalation and progressively develop calming of body, feelings, and mind. As practice continues, the mind becomes calmer, clearer, and steadier, while attention is directed toward impermanence, cessation, and relinquishment. Breathing is to be seen not as “my breathing,” but as a process: an inhalation arises and ceases; an exhalation arises and ceases.

Viewed through the chain of conditions, breathing becomes an object of attention. There is the body, the process of inhalation and exhalation, mindfulness of that process, and clear comprehension of the state of mind. On this basis, mental contact arises, and with it *vedanā*. At first this is often neutral feeling: nothing special seems to be happening. Precisely here, the mind easily becomes bored, searches for another object, controls the breath, or becomes irritated with practice. When there are *sati* and an understanding of conditionality, neutral feeling is recognized as feeling, and the mind need not become agitated.

As calming develops, breathing becomes subtler and neutral feeling may be replaced by a subtly pleasant one. This is not a goal to chase, but a sign that coarser bodily formations are calming. If unusual images, light, a *nimitta*, or pleasant bodily sensations arise, they should be understood as conditioned processes: do not grasp, retain, or turn them into “my attainment.” They need not appear at all.

The Pleasant in Practice and the Danger of Clinging

When the mind becomes sufficiently collected, *pīti* and *sukha* may arise. Both are pleasant aspects of experience, but they do not mean the same thing. *Pīti* is rapture, joyful enlivening,

or inspiration, while *sukha* is happiness, pleasantness, and inner comfort. In the first two jhānas, they are present together; in the third, *pīti* fades while *sukha* remains.

If the mind thinks, “I want more,” “this is mine,” “I attained,” or “I must retain it,” the pleasant becomes food for *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and *bhava*. Even meditative happiness then becomes a condition for future *dukkha*: fear of loss, desire to repeat, and comparison with past experience.

If *pīti* and *sukha* are seen as arisen through conditions, impermanent, and impersonal, the mind need not appropriate them. Rapture can then refine into happiness, happiness into quieter collectedness, and collectedness into equanimity. Transitions among the jhānas occur not through the volition “I am moving onward,” but through relinquishing what is coarser and the natural refinement of experience.

It is more accurate to speak of jhāna not as an event, “I entered a state,” but as a form of collectedness that arises when the necessary conditions are present and can be used in practice. It is not an unconscious blackout: clarity and awareness remain, though thinking quiets. Jhāna is a conditioned process; if afterward there arises “I want to repeat this” or “this is my attainment,” it becomes a condition for *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and *bhava*. Descriptions of jhāna occur in many suttas, for example [MN 119](#).

1. The first jhāna: seclusion from sensual pleasures and unwholesome states, *vitakka-vicāra*, *pīti*, and *sukha*.
2. The second: *vitakka* and *vicāra* subside; inner assurance, *pīti*, and *sukha* grow stronger.
3. The third: *pīti* fades; *sukha*, *sati*, and *upekkhā* remain.
4. The fourth: pleasure and pain have been abandoned; there is purity of *sati* and *upekkhā*.

A useful criterion after practice is: has the mind become gentler, clearer, and freer? Does it seek stimulation less, react less irritably to the unpleasant, cling less to the pleasant, and recognize *vedanā* and *taṇhā* more quickly during the day? If meditation increases pride, hunger for states, fear of losing an experience, or irritation over an “unsuccessful practice,” a new *bhava* is already being built around *samādhi*.

A Happiness That Need Not Be Feared

In [MN 36](#), the Buddha recollects the happiness of the first jhāna and realizes that pleasure separated from sensuality and unwholesome states should not be feared. Practice teaches one to distinguish sensual pleasure connected with craving from happiness that supports calming, collectedness, and letting go. Jhānic happiness is not a sensual pleasure, yet clinging can arise toward it as well.

Four Purposes of Collectedness

[AN 4.41](#) names four directions in the development of *samādhi*.

Development of collectedness	Practical function
The four jhānas	Pleasant abiding here and now.
Perception of light	Knowledge and vision.
The practitioner knows when feelings, perceptions, and thoughts (<i>vitakka</i>) arise, are present, and cease	Mindfulness and clear comprehension.
Contemplating the arising and cessation of processes belonging to the five clinging-aggregates	Cessation of the <i>āsavā</i> .

Collectedness may provide wholesome peace, strengthen clarity, and become a basis for the cessation of defilements. The question “was it pleasant?” is therefore insufficient. It is important to understand what function the practice is serving now and what result it is tending toward.

Impermanence, Dispassion, Cessation, and Relinquishment

In [MN 118](#), *ānāpānasati* is described as contemplation of impermanence, dispassion, cessation, and relinquishment. This is what a rightly collected and clear mind gradually leads toward.

First, impermanence becomes more visible. An inhalation arises and ceases; an exhalation arises and ceases. No two inhalations or exhalations are identical. The feeling associated with breathing changes: the neutral may become subtly pleasant, the pleasant may refine, and *pīti* and *sukha* also arise and cease. Even calm and collectedness depend on conditions.

As impermanence is seen more deeply, passionate clinging to experience weakens. This is *virāga*: the cooling of greedy grasping at what cannot be held.

Cessation then becomes clearer. What has arisen through conditions ceases when those conditions cease. Through practice, the mind begins to understand directly, not merely as an idea, that nothing conditioned can be a reliable support for “I” and “mine.”

From this, relinquishment unfolds more naturally. It is not reducible to the thought “I must let go.” Rather, the mind stops habitually grasping the pleasant, pushing away the unpleasant, and failing to notice the neutral. The chain receives less nourishment.

An Unstable First Jhāna and Traces of the Hindrances

At early stages, the first jhāna may not be fully stable. *Pīti*, *sukha*, clarity, and collectedness may be present, while brief thoughts, doubt, or apprehension still arise at the periphery: “is this jhāna?” “I may be distracted now,” “I will lose this state.” The appearance of such a thought does not necessarily mean the jhāna has ended.

In [AN 10.72](#), sound is called a “thorn” for the first jhāna. This can be understood as a warning about the vulnerability of collectedness that has not yet been fully mastered.

A useful criterion is whether attention has been captured. If restlessness arises as a brief process, is recognized, does not carry the mind away, does not destroy *pīti*, *sukha*, and collectedness, and quickly disappears, it is more likely a trace of a hindrance. If attention is captured, the mind begins constructing a story, the body contracts, awareness of breathing is lost, and the jhāna factors dissolve, the hindrance has become active again.

It is useful to notice fear of losing the state. The thought “I am about to lose this” reveals subtle *upādāna*: the pleasant state is already being appropriated as “my attainment.” Practice here is not a struggle with anxiety, but clear knowing: “fear has arisen,” “there is a wish to retain,” “this is a conditioned process.” Attention then gently returns to breathing, the body, and overall collectedness.

Unusual bodily, luminous, or spatial effects are not the main criterion of jhāna. More important are whether the five *nīvaraṇa* have weakened, whether stability, clarity, *pīti*, *sukha*, and collectedness are present, and whether there is less clinging to the state itself.

In [AN 9.35](#), a practitioner is compared to a mountain cow that loses its former footing by trying to step farther too soon. Wholesome collectedness that has arisen should be developed,

mastered, and strengthened, without trying to force the next state. This is not inaction, but right effort without craving for a result.

[AN 9.36](#) shows how a jhāna or formless attainment can serve as a basis for liberating vision. Relying on the attainment, the practitioner considers the phenomena connected with it as impermanent, unsatisfactory, disintegrating, empty, and impersonal. The mind then turns away from them and inclines toward the Deathless: the calming of all formative activities, the relinquishment of every appropriation, the cessation of craving, dispassion, cessation, and *Nibbāna*.

If this work is completed, the defilements cease. If not, the result may be the ending of the five lower fetters and non-returning.

The sutta compares such practice to the training of an archer. By practicing again and again on a straw target or clay figure, the archer gradually becomes able to shoot far, quickly, and accurately. Liberating vision likewise develops not through a single vivid experience, but through repeated cultivation of collectedness and the skillful direction of a steady mind.

Temporary Abandonment and Final Cessation

The absence of the five hindrances in deep collectedness is not equivalent to their final eradication. After emerging, the corresponding tendencies may manifest again. [AN 4.123](#) shows that a person may enjoy jhāna, desire its repetition, and thereby obtain a corresponding rebirth without attaining liberation.

The depth and pleasantness of a state are therefore not in themselves measures of liberation. What matters is whether collectedness is used to develop wisdom and weaken *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and ignorance.

Important: *jhāna* does not liberate automatically, and not every pleasant meditative state is jhāna. Jhānas can become objects of clinging, grounds for pride, and causes of new *bhava*: “I am an impressive practitioner,” “I attained a special state,” or “I must repeat this.” Even deep collectedness should therefore be seen as a conditioned process, not as a possession or a final experience.

19. The Formless Attainments (*arūpa āyatana*) and *nirodha*

After the four *rūpa* jhānas, the suttas describe four formless attainments: infinite space, infinite consciousness, nothingness, and neither-perception- nor-non-perception. These are subtle attainments, not *Nibbāna*: they are conditioned and may become *bhava* if the mind clings to their peace, emptiness, or exceptional character. They reveal the relative coarseness of sensual experience and *rūpa* and provide material for seeing *anicca*, *dukkha*, and *anattā* even in such subtle states.

The formless attainments can support liberating vision, but according to the suttas they are not an obligatory stage of the path for every practitioner. In [MN 70](#), a person liberated by wisdom is described as not having mastered the formless meditative attainments. Liberation by wisdom does not, however, mean bypassing *samādhi* or taking a shortcut. By developing the ability to enter and investigate the formless attainments, a practitioner may refine collectedness, recognize clinging to subtle states, and use these attainments as a powerful support for liberating vision.

This cosmological framework can also be read as indicating levels of clinging. At the sensual level, the mind clings to pleasant objects. In *rūpa* and *arūpa* attainments, clinging is subtler: not to an object, but to a state, such as peace, space, consciousness, the absence of everything, or the subtle sense “it is good to be here.” Yet all of this remains conditioned.

Coarse clinging wants a pleasant object. Subtler clinging is directed not at an external object but at abiding in a particular state: “I dwell in peace,” “I am this space,” “I attained,” or “I will retain this.” Even refined *samādhī* may thus become a condition for *bhava* when a story of “I” is built around it.

Three Meanings of *nirodha*

Meaning	What is meant
Cessation in <i>paṭiccasamuppāda</i>	With the cessation of a condition, the corresponding part of the chain ceases; for example, without <i>taṇhā</i> , <i>upādāna</i> is not nourished.
<i>Nibbāna</i> as cessation	The cessation of craving, clinging, greed, hatred, and delusion; not a temporary collapse of experience.
<i>Saññāvedayitanirodha</i>	The meditative cessation of perception and feeling, a subtle attainment that should not be confused with final liberation.

The cessation of perception and feeling is attained after fully transcending the attainment of neither-perception-nor-non-perception. It should not be confused with the broader meaning of *nirodha*, which in the suttas also denotes the cessation of particular processes, craving, or suffering. In [MN 43](#), the cessation of perception and feeling is explicitly distinguished from death: vitality and heat remain, and the faculties are not destroyed.

After any deep state, the criterion is one: are *taṇhā*, *māna*, *dosa*, fear, clinging, and ignorance decreasing?

20. Formal Practice and Practice in Daily Life

Refuge in the Three Jewels

Taking refuge in the Buddha, Dhamma, and Sangha means consciously choosing the Three Jewels as the central orientation of one’s life and practice. The Buddha is seen as the teacher who discovered and fully realized the path; the Dhamma as the teaching and practice leading to the cessation of *dukkha*; and the noble Sangha as the example of those who have realized the path. A community of practitioners can provide spiritual support and companionship in practice.

In [SN 45.2](#), good friendship, companionship, and association are called the whole of the spiritual life, because they create favorable conditions for developing the Noble Eightfold Path. A good friend can help one hear the Dhamma, see one’s mistakes, and continue practicing, but each person must still understand and walk the path for themselves.

Refuge strengthens confidence, inspiration, and stability, especially amid fear, doubt, or loss of direction. In [SN 11.3](#), recollection of the Buddha, Dhamma, and Sangha helps overcome fear. In [AN 11.11](#), recollection of the Buddha straightens the mind, followed by joy, tranquility, and collectedness.

The Dhamma and Vinaya as Teacher

In [DN 16](#), the Buddha says that after his departure the Dhamma and Vinaya will be the teacher of his followers. This does not mean blindly following systems or one’s own ideas.

Practice rests on the Dhamma, discipline, and the testing of fruits: what leads to the reduction of *lobha*, *dosa*, and *moha*, to clarity and gentleness, and to liberation from *dukkha*?

It is therefore useful to observe one's own experience attentively: notice which conditions make the mind clearer, calmer, and kinder, and which lead to heaviness and hindrances. Such investigation remains within the Dhamma: it seeks not a special state, but conditions under which the chain receives less nourishment.

Technique and the Conditions of Practice

In [MN 39](#), the four jhānas are presented as part of gradual training. Their preparation consists of purity of conduct and livelihood, guarding the sense doors, moderation in eating, wakefulness, mindfulness and clear comprehension, seclusion, and abandonment of the five hindrances.

This sequence should not be understood as a rigid staircase on which each stage must be fully mastered before the next is approached. It shows that *samādhi* does not arise from a single meditation technique, but rests on one's whole way of life and practice. Many conditions for collectedness are formed outside the meditation session and then support practice within it. For a layperson, wakefulness and diligence do not mean deliberate sleep deprivation or exhaustion. What matters is moderation, clarity, and a reasonable attitude toward the body, not trying to force collectedness through excessive tension.

When overloaded, after a break in practice, or when prolonged sitting turns into a struggle against oneself, it is wiser to begin with short but regular sessions. Their length can gradually increase as stability develops naturally.

A technique is not an end in itself. Its usefulness is determined by whether *lobha*, *dosa*, and *moha* lessen; whether the hindrances and the arising of *taṇhā* after *vedanā* are recognized more clearly; whether collectedness strengthens; and whether clinging to experiences weakens.

Tuning Effort

Meditation should not become the forceful holding of an object, but neither is it passive waiting for calm. In [AN 6.55](#), effort is compared to tuning strings: excessive tension leads to restlessness, while insufficient energy leads to dullness. Effort is adjusted so that the mind remains alert but not constricted.

A pleasant bodily sensation may sometimes serve as a support for calming. If relaxation turns into drowsiness, it may help to straighten up or half-open the eyes; if tension arises, relax control and allow breathing to proceed naturally.

A useful image: attention can rest on a bodily sensation as a seal rests on the shore, steady and relaxed, without trying to squeeze a desired state out of what is happening.

Do Not Measure Practice Only by Attainments

Meditation should not be regarded as unsuccessful merely because no jhāna, rapture, or especially clear state arose. If the right direction was maintained, distractions noticed, hindrances recognized, and attention returned to the meditation object, the session was not fruitless. Sometimes its result lies not in an unusual experience, but in distraction being seen more clearly, a habitual reaction not being continued, or the mind calming even briefly. Skill gradually develops, and the hindrances are recognized earlier and more precisely.

Jhānas are conditioned: they arise not merely at the practitioner's wish, but when the necessary conditions come together and the hindrances temporarily subside. A person

may work honestly every day without receiving wages after every single hour. Likewise, especially calm and deep meditation may be prepared by many ordinary and sometimes difficult sessions. The task is therefore not to squeeze a desired result out of each meditation, but patiently to cultivate its conditions without craving and frustration.

If exhaustion, severe tension, or deterioration regularly remain after practice, this should not be justified by saying “every session is useful.” The duration, object, or method should be reconsidered.

It may also be useful to imagine that this is the last opportunity to practice in this life. If only one hour remained, would it be worth spending it on habitual fantasies, arguments, and plans? This recollection should not produce fear or tension. Its purpose is to cut through what is secondary and return to practice.

In [AN 6.19](#), the Buddha offers an even sharper recollection of death: practice with the understanding that life may last only until the next morsel of food, or the next in-breath and out-breath. The value of this reflection is not gloom, but the development of urgency and heedfulness.

Patience Does Not Mean Inaction

When a condition cannot presently be changed without harm, patience helps one not add a second dart to pain. But when danger, overload, or an unwholesome situation can reasonably be changed, such action is also part of practice.

Accepting the fact “this is how it is now” therefore does not mean deciding “let it remain this way.” Mindfulness helps one see what is happening more clearly and choose the less harmful course.

Liberation Is Not a Spiritual Persona

The cessation of *dukkha* should not be understood as constructing a “saintly” identity in the ordinary religious sense: a special personality, a special spiritual entity, or an ideal image of a practitioner. In the Dhamma, the point is not to create a new spiritual image, but to end craving, clinging, becoming, and ignorance.

Ethical conduct is necessary as a condition of the path: without it, the mind is full of remorse, conflict, and agitation. Unwholesome actions create conditions that obstruct practice. But the goal of the path is not to construct a new identity, “I am holy” or “I am realized.” The goal is that greed, hatred, and delusion no longer govern the mind and the chain of suffering is no longer fed.

Clear Comprehension in Activity

While walking, eating, conversing, working, and resting, it is useful to notice not only the action itself, but its appropriateness: why am I doing this, does it lead to clarity or hindrances, has mindfulness been lost, and is the action driven by craving, irritation, or distraction?

Posture for Sitting Meditation

In [MN 10](#), the Buddha describes the beginning of sitting meditation as follows:

*araññagato vā rukkhamūlagato vā suññāgāragato vā nisīdati, pallaṅkaṃ ābhujitvā,
ujum kāyaṃ paṇidhāya, parimukhaṃ satim upaṭṭhapetvā*

That is, the practitioner goes to a forest, the root of a tree, or an empty shelter; sits down with the legs folded in *pallaṅka*; holds the body upright; and establishes mindfulness to the fore.

Pallaṅkam ābhujitvā indicates sitting with the legs crossed and literally suggests folding the legs into a cross-legged posture. More important, however, are suitable conditions for practice: a quiet or secluded place, a stable and comfortable posture, an upright back, and mindfulness. If the body does not permit cross-legged sitting without pain and unnecessary tension, another posture may be used, such as sitting on a chair.

Practice in the Moment

When the mind has been caught by something, three questions are enough:

1. What was the *phassa*?
2. What *vedanā* arose?
3. What *taṇhā* is beginning to move?

If there is a little more clarity, add:

4. What is the mind clinging to?
5. What kind of “I” is being born now?
6. What will follow from it?

Retrospective Practice

Choose a single episode and break it down:

- Contact.
- Feeling.
- Craving.
- Clinging.
- Becoming.
- Birth of a role.
- Cost of the role.
- Where could the chain have been left unfed?

Over time, the mind begins to recognize the chain earlier.

21. Worksheets

Worksheet 1: the Unpleasant

1. What happened?
2. What was the *phassa*?
3. What was the *vedanā*?
4. What was the *taṇhā*?
5. What does the mind want to obtain from the object or action: relief, control, aliveness, flow, belonging, fantasy, or escape from dissatisfaction?
6. What happens to the feeling, bodily impulse, and mental story if the pull is not given its habitual nourishment for a short time?
7. What is the *upādāna*?
8. What is the *bhava*?
9. What “I” was born?
10. What is the cost of this state?
11. Where can the chain be opened?

Worksheet 2: the Pleasant

1. What pleasant experience arose?
2. How did the body feel it?

3. Was there a wish to prolong, repeat, or secure it?
4. What self-image did the mind begin to construct?
5. Did dependence on recognition, taste, success, or a state arise?
6. Can the pleasant be allowed to end without residual hunger?

Worksheet 3: Desire

1. What does the desire promise?
2. What does it want to remove or obtain?
3. Are fatigue, anxiety, boredom, loneliness, or pain behind it?
4. What will happen if it is indulged automatically?
5. What will happen if it is suppressed?
6. What does the middle way look like: understand, do not feed, choose?

Worksheet 4: *samādhi*

1. Which hindrance was predominant before practice?
2. Was the mind calming, or being forcibly constricted?
3. Did pleasantness arise naturally, or was the mind trying to reproduce it?
4. Did clarity remain together with calm?
5. Which conditions helped collectedness arise?
6. Which hindrances were absent, and which merely quieted temporarily?
7. After practice, did it become easier to recognize *vedanā* - *taṇhā*?
8. Did clinging to repetition, comparison, attainment, or status arise?
9. What should be developed next without turning practice into a hunt for a state?

Worksheet 5: Speech and Action

This worksheet follows the general logic of [MN 61](#): examine an action before, during, and after it.

Before the Action

1. What am I about to say or do?
2. What intention leads the action: goodwill, protection, irritation, the desire to win, to obtain approval, or to avoid the unpleasant?
3. Could the action cause harm to me, another person, or both?
4. Can a reasonable aim be achieved in a less harmful way?

During the Action

5. What is happening in body and mind right now?
6. Are craving, hostility, or confusion becoming stronger?
7. What consequences are already visible?
8. Should I continue, change the manner of acting, or stop?

After the Action

9. What are the actual consequences for me, other people, and relationships?
10. Did they match what the mind expected?

11. If the action was unwholesome, what should be acknowledged, repaired, or not repeated?
12. What condition should be changed before a similar situation in the future?

22. Short Reminders

Five Frequent Recollections

AN 5.57 lists five themes for frequent recollection:

- I am subject to aging and have not gone beyond aging;
- I am subject to illness and have not gone beyond illness;
- I am subject to death and have not gone beyond death;
- I must be separated from everything dear and pleasing to me;
- I am the heir of my actions: whatever I do, wholesome or unwholesome, will become my inheritance.

These recollections serve sobriety: they weaken heedlessness and help one choose actions of body, speech, and mind more carefully.

A *vedanā* Reminder

The pleasant is not mine.

The unpleasant is not mine.

The neutral is not mine.

But this is not a denial of experience. It is seeing that feeling arises through conditions and ceases through conditions.

A *taṇhā* Reminder

Taṇhā says:

- “more”;
- “remove it”;
- “hold it”;
- “prove it”;
- “become”;
- “disappear.”

An *upādāna* Reminder

Where is “mine”?

- being right;
- my image;
- my pleasure;
- my pain;
- my path;
- my realization;
- my opinion;
- my control.

A *bhava* Reminder

What mode of existence has switched on?

- the offended me;
- the defender me;
- the winner me;
- the victim me;
- the loved me;
- the special me;
- the controller me;
- the practitioner me.

23. Glossary of Pali Terms

Adosa

Non-hatred: the absence of aversion, hostility, and the urge to reject. It is one of the three wholesome roots, together with *alobha* and *amoha*. *Adosa* does not mean weakness, submission, or the loss of boundaries. It means that the mind does not wish to harm, humiliate, suppress, or destroy. It is the opposite of *dosa*.

Ahaṅkāra

“I-making”: identification and the appropriation of experience as “this is me.” It is close in meaning to the formula *eso’ham asmi*, “this I am.”

Anattā

Not-self, impersonality. This is not the nihilistic assertion that “nothing exists.” It means that no independent, permanent, governing self can be found in the aggregates or in conditioned processes.

Anusaya

An underlying tendency or latent disposition. It need not be present as an overt thought or emotion, but may manifest when suitable conditions arise. Pleasant *vedanā* can sustain the underlying tendency to passion, unpleasant *vedanā* the tendency to aversion, and neutral *vedanā* the tendency to ignorance.

Anicca

Impermanence. Whatever has arisen changes and ceases.

Ariyasacca

A noble truth, “noble” in origin and scope. It is not merely a proposition, but something to be fully understood, abandoned, realized, or developed.

Arūpa āyatana

The four formless attainments: the dimensions of infinite space, infinite consciousness, nothingness, and neither-perception-nor-non-perception. These are subtle conditioned attainments, not Nibbāna.

Asaṅkhata

The unmade, the unconditioned. It is the opposite of *saṅkhata*: made, compounded, conditioned.

Āsavā

Taints, corrupting currents, or deep flows of defilement: sensuality, becoming, ignorance, and related tendencies. *Āsavakkhaya* means their exhaustion.

Ātāpī

Diligent, ardent, energetic. The term uses the image of heat, but does not imply self-torment. It points to bright, sustained energy that does not let the mind drift away or feed the unwholesome, and that maintains clarity.

Attavādupādāna

Clinging to a doctrine or idea of self. It can take subtle forms: “I am consciousness,” “I am pure knowing,” or “Nibbāna is my true self.” Here the craving for existence seeks a new foothold.

Avijjā

Ignorance, distorted seeing: taking the impermanent as permanent, the unsatisfactory as satisfactory, the impersonal as personal, and the unattractive as beautiful.

Avippaṭisāra

Absence of remorse. It arises when conduct leaves no unwholesome trace in the mind and supports joy and collectedness.

Bhava

Becoming, continued existence: the formation and continuation of a mode of existence through clinging. In the full-scale account of dependent origination it leads toward renewed birth. In practical examination it may also be seen in a role or identity taking shape. It should not, however, be reduced to a single momentary psychological state.

Bhāvanā

Development or cultivation of the conditions of the path. It is neither mechanical production nor violence against oneself. One purifies conduct, directs attention, strengthens *sati*, gathers the mind, and develops wise seeing. As conditions change, experience changes.

Cetanā

Intention or volitional impulse. It directs action by body, speech, and mind. In experience it may be noticed as: “now I will answer,” “obtain this,” or “hold on to this.”

Dhamma

The Buddha’s teaching, truth, a phenomenon, or the lawfulness of experience. Practically, it is what leads toward the cessation of *dukkha*. The word may also refer to psychophysical phenomena; its meaning depends on context.

Dosa

Aversion, rejection, irritation, or hostility. It is one of the three unwholesome roots, together with *lobha* and *moha*. Under *dosa*, the mind wants to remove, suppress, strike, destroy, or reject an unpleasant object. This should be distinguished from clearly discerning harm: one can set boundaries or stop an unwholesome action without hatred. *Dosa* feeds harshness, hostility, harsh speech, inner violence, and *dukkha*.

Dukkha

Unsatisfactoriness, painfulness, instability of the conditioned, suffering. It is not limited to gross pain. It also includes the subtler unreliability of everything that arises through conditions, changes, and disintegrates.

Indriya-saṃvara

Restraint of the sense faculties. This is not closing oneself off from life, but wisely caring for which contacts are admitted and how the mind engages with them.

Jarāmaraṇa

Aging-and-death. Whatever is born breaks down. On a smaller experiential scale, roles and identities lose their support and may bring anxiety, fatigue, remorse, and *dukkha*.

Jāti

Birth. In dependent origination, this is the birth of a new existence. In immediate practice it can also be examined through the birth of a particular “I-state.”

Jhāna

Meditative collectedness. The standard formula describes four *rūpa jhānas*. They are valuable for purifying and stabilizing the mind, but are not to be made into objects of clinging.

Khandhā

The five aggregates: *rūpa*, *vedanā*, *saññā*, *saṅkhārā*, and *viññāṇa*. They become objects of clinging when taken as “I” or “mine.”

Lobha

Greed, avarice, grasping desire. It is one of the three unwholesome roots, together with *dosa* and *moha*, and is closely related to *taṇhā* and *rāga*. Under *lobha*, the mind reaches toward an object and wants to obtain it, retain it, repeat it, or make it “mine.” This should be distinguished from a wholesome wish to practise. *Lobha* feeds appropriation, clinging, and *bhava*.

Magga

The path. In the framework of the early suttas, this is the Noble Eightfold Path, cultivated through ethics, collectedness, and wisdom.

Mamaṅkāra

“Mine-making”: appropriating experience as “this is mine,” corresponding to the formula *etaṃ mama*.

Māna

Conceit, or subtle comparison organized around “I”: “I am,” “I am above,” “below,” or “equal,” “I understood.” It is not limited to gross pride; it includes subtle centering of experience around “I am.”

Mettā

Goodwill, loving-kindness: wishing for another’s welfare without self-interest.

Moha

Delusion, confusion, obscuration, or misapprehension. It is one of the three unwholesome roots, together with *lobha* and *dosa*. It is not merely a lack of information, but a distortion in which the impermanent appears stable, the conditioned independent, and the impersonal “I” or “mine.” It is closely related to *avijjā*. In this document, *avijjā* refers more broadly to ignorance of the Four Noble Truths and conditionality, while *moha* often denotes the concrete obscuration from which unwholesome intentions arise.

Muditā

Appreciative joy in the welfare, success, or happiness of others, without envy or appropriation.

Nāma-rūpa

Name-and-form, the psychophysical complex. *Nāma* includes feeling, perception, intention, contact, and attention; *rūpa* is material form.

Nibbāna

The unborn, unoriginated, unmade; liberation, the extinguishing of craving, hatred, and ignorance. It is not an ordinary state that can be appropriated or held.

Nibbidā

Disenchantment, disillusionment, or detachment from clinging to the conditioned. It is not depression, anhedonia, or disgust with life, but the sober ending of the search for final support where no such support can be found.

Nirodha

Cessation. Depending on context, it may refer to the cessation of a particular link, the cessation of *dukkha*, Nibbāna, or the cessation of perception and feeling.

Pamojja

Joy, inspiration, or clear uplift born of a wholesome direction. It is not sensual euphoria, but a healthy enlivening of the mind.

Papañca

Mental proliferation, self-narrative, conceptual multiplication. This is not every instance of thought, but proliferation around “I,” “mine,” and “for me”: elaborating, fantasizing, arguing, comparing, defending, replaying, and constructing worlds. It is fed by *taṇhā*, *māna*, views, and *avijjā*.

Paṭinissagga

Relinquishment, letting go. It is not a command imposed by will, but the weakening of grasping through seeing conditions, impermanence, and cessation. When what is held can no longer be taken as a reliable support, clinging loses nourishment.

Phassa

Contact: the meeting of a sense faculty, its object, and the corresponding consciousness. *Vedanā* arises dependent on contact.

Saddhā

Confidence or trust. It is not blind acceptance, but the confidence that motivates practice and verification.

Sakkāya-diṭṭhi

Identity view based on the five aggregates: regarding body, feeling, perception, formations, or consciousness as self, as belonging to self, as contained within self, or as containing self. Practically, it is the appropriation and construction of “I” and “mine.”

Salāyatana

The six sense fields: eye, ear, nose, tongue, body, and mind, together with their corresponding objects.

Sampajañña

Clear comprehension of events, actions, intentions, appropriateness, the state of mind, and relevant conditions. It works closely together with *sati*.

Samudaya

The arising or origin of *dukkha*. In the Four Noble Truths it points primarily to *taṇhā* as the source that sustains suffering.

Saṅkhārā

Formations or formative activities. Depending on context, the word may refer to conditioned phenomena generally, bodily, verbal, and mental formations in dependent origination, or intentions, especially *cetanā*, within the aggregate of formations.

Saññā

Perception, recognition, labeling. The mind recognizes, names, and connects an object with memory: “praise,” “danger,” “mine.”

Saññāvedayitanirodha

The cessation of perception and feeling. This is a particular meditative attainment, not an intellectual idea of emptiness or simple unconsciousness.

Sati

Mindfulness, recollection, the ability to return to and maintain the relevant object or frame. It is not vague observation. It supports clear knowing of body, feeling, mind, and *dhammā*. Depending on context it may be rendered as mindfulness, recollection, awareness, or attentive presence.

Taṇhā

Craving. It is not every functional desire, but the clinging pull toward sensual pleasure, becoming, or non-becoming. Its flavor is: “let it be as I want.”

Upādāna

Clinging, appropriation, holding on. *Taṇhā* condenses into “mine”: my view, pleasure, rightness, image, or path. The term is sometimes translated as attachment or grasping, but should be distinguished from wholesome striving. It is the grasping of an object, state, opinion, ritual, or idea of self that sustains *bhava*.

Upanisā

A supporting condition or proximate support. In [SN 12.23](#), *dukkha* can become a supporting condition for *saddhā* when it is understood as the conditioned unreliability that makes the path necessary.

Upekkhā

Equanimity, even-mindedness, balance. It is not coldness, but stability without clinging or rejection.

Vedanā

Feeling tone: pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral. It is not yet an emotion or a narrative. *Taṇhā* often begins here.

Vicikicchā

Doubt, uncertainty, or indecision that prevents confident continuation. As a hindrance it clouds the mind and weakens wisdom. In [MN 16](#), doubt concerning the Teacher, the Dhamma, the Saṅgha, or the training obstructs diligence and persistence. As a fetter it is abandoned at stream-entry. The term does not cover every question, but rather paralyzing doubt that keeps the mind in indecision even when the direction is sufficiently clear.

Vimutti

Liberation: the mind freed from clinging, craving, hostility, and ignorance. It is not a status or self-image, but the cessation of what sustains *dukkha*.

Vinaya

Discipline, training, a canonical division, and a way of maintaining life under conditions that support the path. In a broad practical sense it is not merely a collection of rules, but a form that protects practice from disorder.

Viññāṇa

Consciousness as awareness of an object: visual, auditory, olfactory, gustatory, bodily, or mental. It arises dependent on conditions and is not an independent bearer of experience or a hidden self that owns it.

Virāga

Dispassion, the fading of passion, the cooling of greedy interest in the conditioned. It is not lifelessness or suppression, but the weakening of clinging to what arises and ceases.

Yoniso manasikāra

Wise direction of attention: seeing causes, conditions, arising, and cessation.

24. Supporting Suttas and Sources for Verification

The list below is not exhaustive. These are sources for checking the principal themes.

- [SN 56.11 Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta](#): the Four Noble Truths; in the Pali version, knowledge-and-vision of the four truths is developed through three rounds and twelve aspects.
- [SN 12.2 Vibhaṅga Sutta](#): the expanded formula of dependent origination; bodily, verbal, and mental *saṅkhārā*.
- [SN 12.15 Kaccānagotta Sutta](#): avoiding the extremes of existence and non-existence.
- [SN 12.23 Upanisā Sutta](#): the liberating sequence of conditions from *dukkha* to *saddhā*, *samādhi*, *nibbidā*, *virāga*, and *vimutti*.
- [DN 2 Sāmaññaphala Sutta](#): gradual training through *sīla*, sense restraint, *sati-sampajañña*, contentment, abandonment of the five hindrances, the four *jhānas*, and knowledge of liberation.
- [DN 15 Mahānidāna Sutta](#): the mutual dependence of *viññāṇa* and *nāma-rūpa*, and *nāma-rūpa* as a basis for *phassa*.
- [DN 16 Mahāparinibbāna Sutta](#): the Dhamma and Vinaya as teacher after the Buddha's passing.

- [MN 29 Mahāsāropama Sutta](#): *vimutti* as the heartwood of the holy life: not honor, morality, collectedness, or knowledge in themselves, but liberation of mind.
- [MN 22 Alagaddūpama Sutta](#): the Dhamma as a raft for crossing over, and the danger of grasping the teaching wrongly, like taking a snake by the wrong end.
- [SN 35.28 Ādittapariyāya Sutta](#): seeing the six sense fields as burning with passion, hatred, and delusion gives rise to *nibbidā*, *virāga*, and *vimutti*.
- [MN 28 Mahāhatthipadopama Sutta](#): one who sees dependent origination sees the Dhamma.
- [SN 35.23 Sabba Sutta](#): “the all” as the six sense fields of experience.
- [SN 22.59 Anattalakkhaṇa Sutta](#): the five aggregates as *anattā*.
- [MN 148 Chachakka Sutta](#): the six sextets, contact, feeling, craving, not-self, and the relation of pleasant, unpleasant, and neutral feeling to the tendencies toward passion, aversion, and ignorance.
- [AN 6.63 Nibbedhika Sutta](#): intention as *kamma*; sensuality as passionate intention toward attractive objects.
- [SN 51.13](#) / [SN 51.20](#): *chanda* as one basis for developing collectedness and effort (*idhipāda*).
- [AN 8.53 Gotamī Sutta](#): criteria for what accords with the Dhamma and Vinaya (*Dhamma-Vinaya*).
- [SN 45.8 Magga-vibhaṅga Sutta](#): the Noble Eightfold Path.
- [MN 2 Sabbāsava Sutta](#): different ways of abandoning the *āsavā*: seeing, restraint, use, endurance, avoidance, removal, and development.
- [MN 20 Vitakkasaṇṭhāna Sutta](#): practical methods for working with unwholesome thoughts.
- [MN 5](#): honest diagnosis of stains in the mind, seeing a defilement when it is present and its absence when it is absent.
- [MN 9](#): right view as understanding a phenomenon, its origin, its cessation, and the path to its cessation.
- [MN 18 Madhupīṇḍika Sutta](#): contact, feeling, perception, thought, and *papañca*.
- [SN 46.51](#): the nourishment and non-nourishment of the hindrances and awakening factors.
- [SN 46.53](#): balancing the factors: investigation, energy, and joy are needed during sluggishness; tranquility, collectedness, and equanimity during agitation.
- [SN 4.4](#): wise direction of attention and right effort as a concise statement of the path’s working heart.
- [SN 4.5](#): the Dhamma is good in the beginning, good in the middle, and good in the end.
- [SN 4.7](#): an example of practice after walking meditation: the lion’s posture, mindfulness, clear comprehension, and attention to the time for rising.
- [AN 11.1](#) / [AN 11.2](#): virtue, absence of remorse, joy, tranquility, collectedness, knowledge-and-vision, and liberation.
- [AN 10.13](#): the ten fetters (*saṃyojana*) and their relation to the stages of awakening.
- [MN 10](#) / [DN 22 Satipaṭṭhāna](#): the four establishments of mindfulness, the five hindrances, and the seven awakening factors as part of contemplating *dhammā*; also the standard formula for seated meditation: a suitable place, *pallaṅkaṃ*, an upright back, and established mindfulness.
- [MN 62 Mahārāhulovāda Sutta](#): the elements, breathing, and contemplations taught to Rāhula.
- [MN 118 Ānāpānasati Sutta](#): breathing, the four establishments of mindfulness, and the seven awakening factors.
- [MN 119 Kāyagatāsati Sutta](#): mindfulness of the body and the description of the four jhānas in the context of bodily mindfulness and collectedness.

- [Iti 43 / Ud 8.3](#): the unborn, unoriginated, unmade.
- [MN 26 Ariyapariyesanā Sutta](#): the noble search and the limitations of formless attainments as a final goal.
- [MN 43 Mahāvedalla Sutta](#): the interconnection of feeling, perception, and consciousness; questions concerning the cessation of perception and feeling.
- [MN 121 Cūḷasuññata Sutta](#): gradual abiding in emptiness.
- [MN 106 Āneñjasappāya Sutta](#): the path to the imperturbable and subtle meditative supports.
- [DN 1 Brahmajāla Sutta](#): a broad survey of speculative views.
- [MN 13 Mahādukkhakkhandha Sutta](#): gratification, danger, and escape in relation to sensual pleasures.
- [MN 19 Dvedhāvitakka Sutta](#): two directions of thought and the mind's habitual inclination.
- [MN 21 Kakacūpama Sutta](#): maintaining goodwill and freedom from inner hatred in the face of abuse.
- [MN 36 Mahāsaccaka Sutta](#): the happiness of the first jhāna, which need not be feared.
- [MN 38 Mahātaṇhāsāṅkhaya Sutta](#): consciousness arises dependent on conditions and is not an unchanging entity.
- [MN 41 Sāleyyaka Sutta](#): unwholesome and wholesome conduct by body, speech, and mind.
- [MN 61 Ambalaṭṭhikarāhulovāda Sutta](#): examining an action before, during, and after it.
- [MN 64 Mahāmālukya Sutta](#): underlying tendencies, the lower fetters, and their abandonment.
- [MN 75 Māgaṇḍiya Sutta](#): the image of scratching sores and liberation from sensual craving.
- [MN 117 Mahācattārīsaka Sutta](#): right and wrong path factors, and right collectedness with its seven supports.
- [SN 35.63 Paṭhamamigajāla Sutta](#): craving as a companion even in external solitude.
- [SN 36.6 Salla Sutta](#): the first and second darts.
- [SN 47.5 Kusalarāsi Sutta](#): the five hindrances as the mass of the unwholesome and the four establishments of mindfulness as the mass of the wholesome.
- [AN 4.41 Samādhībhāvanā Sutta](#): four purposes for developing collectedness.
- [AN 4.123 Paṭhamanānākaraṇa Sutta](#): clinging to jhāna and the rebirth conditioned by it.
- [AN 4.162 Vitthāra Sutta](#): painful and pleasant modes of practice.
- [AN 4.170 Yuganaddha Sutta](#): different relations between tranquility and insight.
- [AN 5.177 Vaṇijjā Sutta](#): five kinds of trade a lay follower should avoid.
- [AN 6.19 Paṭhamamaraṇassati Sutta](#): recollection of death and a sense of urgency.
- [AN 6.61 Majjhe Sutta](#): craving as the seamstress that stitches becoming together.
- [AN 7.11 Paṭhamaanusaya Sutta](#): the seven underlying tendencies.
- [AN 9.35 Gāvūpamā Sutta](#): mastering an attained basis without moving on prematurely.
- [AN 9.36 Jhāna Sutta](#): jhāna and the first three formless attainments as bases for liberating vision.
- [Sn̐p 1.8 Mettā Sutta](#): goodwill, freedom from contempt, and not wishing suffering upon another.
- [Dhp 5](#): hostility is not calmed by hostility.
- [Dhp 334–336, 347](#): images of a creeping vine, grass growing back, and a spider in its own web.
- [SN 11.3 Dhajagga Sutta](#): recollection of the Buddha, Dhamma, and Saṅgha as a support in the face of fear.

- [AN 11.11 Paṭhama Mahānāma Sutta](#): recollection of the Buddha, straightening the mind, joy, tranquility, and collectedness.
- [Iti 50 Mūla Sutta](#): the three unwholesome roots: *lobha*, *dosa*, and *moha*.
- [SN 35.82 Lokapañhā Sutta](#): the “world” as arising and ceasing sense fields, consciousness, contact, and feeling.
- [AN 10.61 Avijjā Sutta](#): no beginning of ignorance can be discovered, but the conditions that feed it can be discerned.
- [AN 10.72 Kaṇṭaka Sutta](#): sound as a “thorn” for the first jhāna.
- [MN 135 Cūḷakammavibhaṅga Sutta](#): inheriting the consequences of one’s own actions.
- [MN 136 Mahākammavibhaṅga Sutta](#): the complexity of the ripening of *kamma* and the danger of mechanical conclusions.
- [SN 12.38 Cetanā Sutta](#): intention, planning, and sustained tendencies as conditions supporting further becoming.
- [SN 36.21 Sīvaka Sutta](#): not every feeling is conditioned solely by past *kamma*.
- [MN 39 Mahāassapura Sutta](#): gradual training, abandonment of the hindrances, and the four jhānas.
- [AN 6.55 Soṇa Sutta](#): tuning effort through the image of a string’s tension.
- [AN 9.7 Sutavā Sutta](#): actions an arahant monk is incapable of performing intentionally.
- [SN 5.2 Somā Sutta](#): women’s capacity for liberation and the distinction between a conventional designation and an appropriated identity.
- [SN 22.1 Nakulapitu Sutta](#): the fourfold formula of *sakkāya-diṭṭhi* applied to each of the five aggregates.
- [MN 95 Caṅkī Sutta](#): extended investigation of a teacher’s stable qualities.
- [MN 70 Kūṭāgiri Sutta](#): seven kinds of noble disciples, including one liberated by wisdom.
- [Dhp 19–20](#): textual knowledge without practice, and a little knowledge embodied in life.
- [AN 5.51 Āvaraṇa Sutta](#): the five hindrances as states that weaken wisdom and obstruct understanding one’s own welfare, the welfare of others, and the welfare of both.
- [AN 5.57 Abhiṇhapaccavekkhitabbaṭṭhāna Sutta](#): five themes for frequent reflection: aging, illness, death, separation from what is dear, and recollection that one is heir to one’s actions.
- [AN 7.65 Hirīottappa Sutta](#): *hiri* and *ottappa* as conditions for guarding the senses.
- [SN 22.56 Upādānaparipavatta Sutta](#): the aggregate of *saṅkhārā* as six classes of intention.
- [SN 45.2 Upaḍḍha Sutta](#): good friendship, companionship, and association as a condition for developing the Noble Eightfold Path.
- [MN 16 Cetokhila Sutta](#): doubt concerning the Teacher, the Dhamma, the Saṅgha, and the training as an obstacle to diligence and progress.

Useful Materials

The books and other materials used in preparing these notes are listed below.

YouTube channels

- [Kalyana Dhamma](#): sutta analyses and practical explanations.
- [ИСКОННЫЙ БУДДА \(Primordial Buddha\)](#): the author’s practical interpretations and material for critical comparison with the suttas.
- [Adi Dhamma](#): materials on terminology and the historical context of Buddhist teachings; interpretations to be critically checked against the early suttas.

Individual playlists

- [A Course on Early Buddhist Meditation](#), Bhante Sujato.
- [Dependent Origination in Early Buddhism](#), Ajahn Brahmali and Bhante Sujato.

- *Mahāsatipaṭṭhāna Sutta*, Bhante Sujato.
- *Paṭiccasamuppāda: Dependent Origination*, Ajahn Brahmali.
- Bhante Devamitta, *Satipaṭṭhāna*.

Books and texts

- Bhikkhu Sujato, *Satipaṭṭhāna Mūla: The Root Focuses of Mindfulness*: a comparative study of early versions of the teaching on the four *satipaṭṭhānas* and a reconstruction of their proposed common basis.
- Bhikkhu Sujato, *A History of Mindfulness*: the history of *satipaṭṭhāna*, the relationship between *samatha* and *vipassanā*, and the comparative and historical context of the early texts.
- Bhikkhu Sujato and Bhikkhu Brahmali, *The Authenticity of the Early Buddhist Texts*: arguments for the reliability of the early Buddhist texts and the comparative reading of the Nikāyas and Āgamas.
- Bhikkhu Bodhi, *In the Buddha's Words*: a thematic anthology of suttas from the Pali Canon.
- Ṭhānissaro Bhikkhu, *With Each and Every Breath*: a practical guide to breath meditation.
- Leigh Brasington, *Right Concentration*: a modern practical map of the jhānas, useful as one interpretation rather than a final standard.
- Bhikkhu Anālayo, *Satipaṭṭhāna Meditation: A Practice Guide*: practical clarifications concerning the four establishments of mindfulness, contemplation of the body, feelings, mind, hindrances, and awakening factors.
- Ajahn Brahm, *Mindfulness, Bliss, and Beyond*: used selectively as a source of practical advice on letting go, the hindrances, sustained attention, and walking meditation. Its model of *nimitta*, “beautiful breath,” and the shutting down of the senses is best regarded as a highly specific interpretation.